Varanasi, 7 pm | Sunset Prayer Ceremony by the Holy River Ganges
Captured by a Creative Travel team member

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Pure
LIFE EXPERIENCES

THE LIST

Marrakech Palais Des Congrès
4th EDITION
12-15 NOV 2012

MOROCCO

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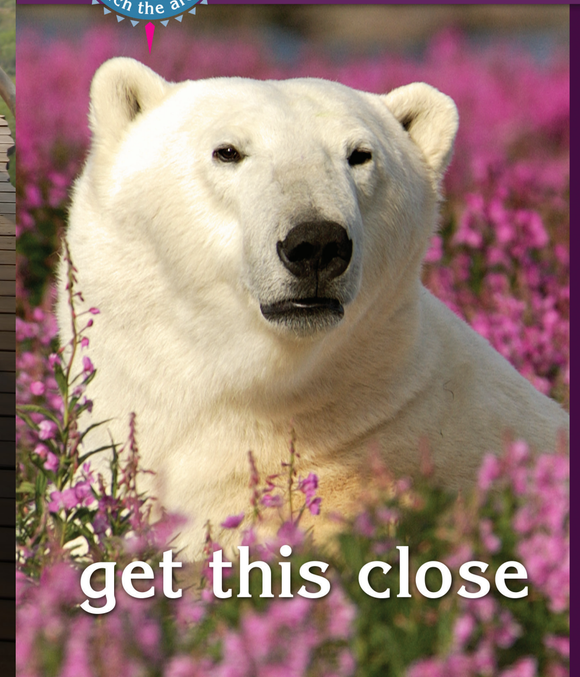

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WELCOME TO PURE 2012

Dear PUREists,

A warm welcome to the fourth edition of PURE Life Experiences in the stunning city of Marrakech. We are delighted to see so many of you here for what will be our most exciting year to date.

2012 has been an outstanding time for Experiential Travel, breaking boundaries for the industry as we know it. Experiential Travel has been deep-rooted into our community and our customers' DNA, as high-emotion, impactful and life-changing experiences are no longer a luxury, but a necessity. The reach and impact of Experiential Travel is growing; for example this year sees an increase of over 40% in new buyers including those from Brazil - as trends predicted - and a rise in new suppliers from Central American destinations in particular. These new suppliers and buyers have recognised the opportunity to create, market and sell meaningful travel experiences to a growing and highly engaged consumer audience, proving there is an ever-evolving scope for our industry.

In a time and place where actions speak louder than words, our PURE community has truly positioned Experiential Travel in the global market place and ensured PURE is the must attend event on the annual calendar. As we continue to explore richer ways to move, cherish new perspective and continually yearn to be immersed in authenticity, high-end Experience Suppliers continue to be perfectly matched with Private Travel Designers and through these collaborations clients are connected with truly powerful experiences.

Experiential Travel is a mind-set, a combination of physical action, challenge and an emotional desire to improve our personal well-being and to savour life enriching experiences. At this year's PURE Life Experiences, we will be exploring the concept of challenger brands in relation to the Experiential Travel community. Along with Adam Morgan – brand strategist and author of celebrated 'Eating the Big Fish', we will address how we, as a community, can differentiate from the archetypal brands and how attitudes in business are symbiotic with thought processes within our community. Alongside this, we will be drawing inspiration from those confronting physical, mental and business challenges, hearing their stories and considering how these learnings can be applied to our own situation.

As another exciting year culminates in the gathering of our spirited community, now is our time to prosper and build upon our creativity, one where PUREists are challenging the travel world for the better and continuing to create memorable, powerful and life-enriching experiences. With Experiential Travel embedded in our sense of sustainability, we are the community of driven, visionary and forward-thinking individuals - constantly pushing boundaries, and seeking out the transformational and authentic travel experiences. We are PUREists.

Our PURE community's global reach continues to expand and now anything is truly possible. As we gather this week in Marrakech we hope you take away more than memories, create more meaningful connections and enjoy all that PURE Life Experiences has to offer.

Once again, welcome and we hope you enjoy a fantastic week.

Serge Dive
Founder & CEO

Sarah Ball
Co-Founder & COO

WELCOME TO MARRAKECH

Abdelhamid Addou

CEO of the Moroccan National Tourist Office

Dear PUREists,

We are proud and honoured to host the fourth edition of PURE Life Experiences, now a global reference for the travel industry-in Marrakech. With an increase every year in the number of both buyers and suppliers, the fact that Marrakech plays host to the fourth consecutive year of PURE Life Experiences only goes to show how NATURALLY PURE this city is! Marrakech has flourished and become known as an exceptional and attractive destination all over the world. A unique cultural heritage destination that is immersed in breathtaking landscapes and unparalleled contrast while providing world class infrastructures…

It is an authentic experience to holidaymakers in search of PURE inspiration. Where better than Morocco and its key destination Marrakech to host such an event? What better than living a rewarding soul experience through the city's culture and its magic that holds the city and amazes its visitors?

PUREists, the Moroccan experience you are about to embark on, will enlighten your stay, travel within you and remain in your memories. A sensation that will be revived each time one of your clients travels to Morocco. Morocco's natural diversity combined with its cultural heritage, values and traditions are assets which the Kingdom is committed to preserving while embracing modernity. These are also, as you will agree, the foundations of PURE Life Experiences.

Allow me to invite you to take part fully in the resounding success of PURE's concept while wishing you successful business opportunities and of course, a pleasant stay in Marrakech.

Hamid Bentahar

President of the CRT Marrakech

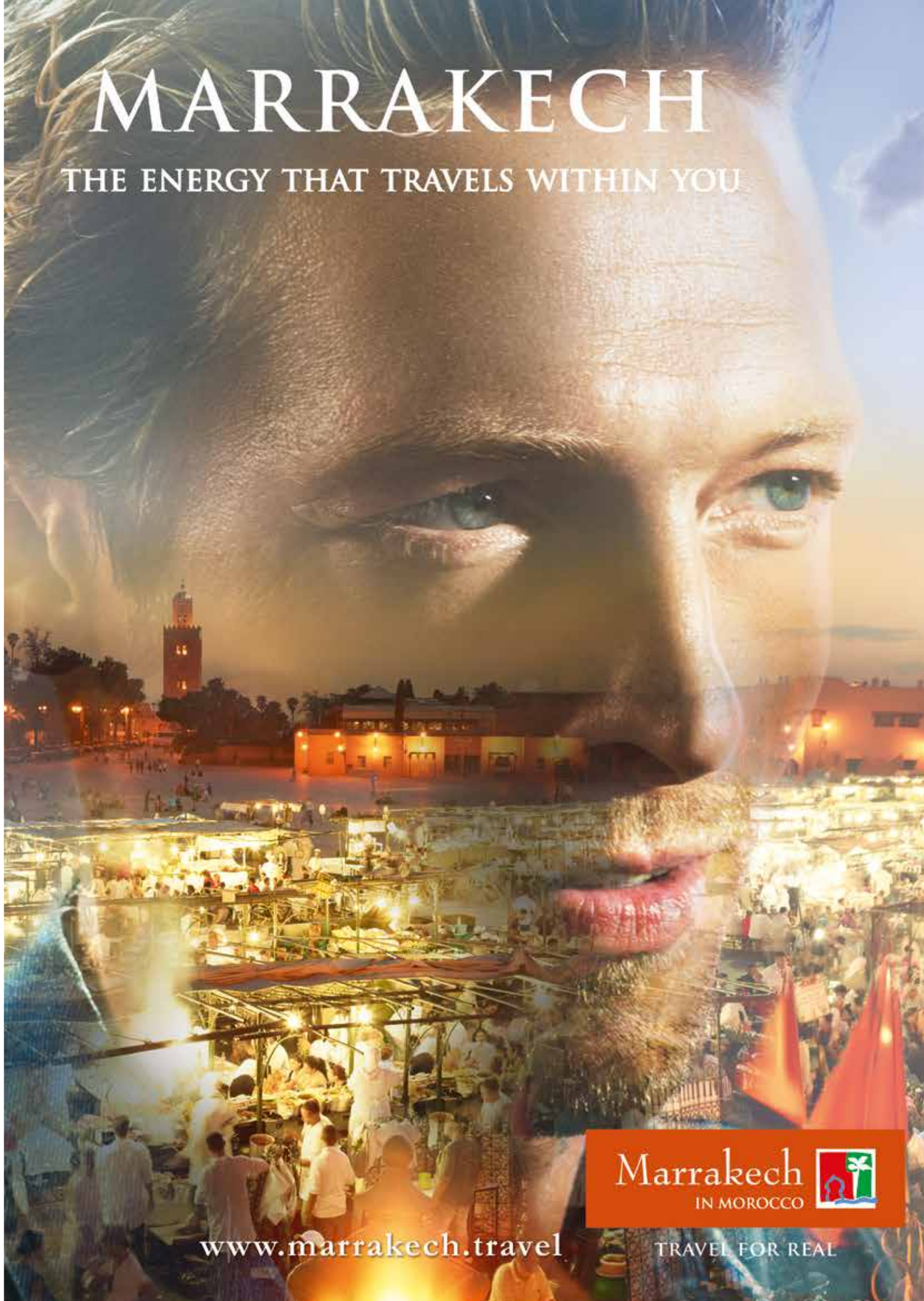
Dear PUREists,

Welcome to the magical and enchanting city of Marrakech. Over the years, Marrakech has established worldwide recognition for its experiential offering: the delicious cuisine, hidden gems and magnificent riads, all in the middle of the desert yet surrounded by the spectacular snow-capped Atlas mountains. Today, it appeals to the high-end traveller as a result of its new energy, glamour and class. The old and the new world have come together to offer a truly magnificent travel destination. The hybrid of cultural influences is second to none, making Marrakech a place of charm and allurement for the new millennium traveller.

Welcome to the Palais des Congrès, a convention centre that welcomes major international events throughout the year, renowned for its professionalism and capacity to host the most prestigious and productive events.

PURE Life Experiences has become the must-attend event for the Experiential Travel industry since 2009 and the city of Marrakech looks forward to hosting this revolutionary event yet again. I would like to take this opportunity to congratulate the organisers of PURE and I wish them every success.

I hope you have a truly memorable stay and a life enriching experience during your time in Marrakech and at PURE.



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Photos of Morroco courtesy of Moroccan National Tourist Office

Beyond Luxury Media Ltd would like to thank those exhibitors who supplied images to illustrate the The List 2012.

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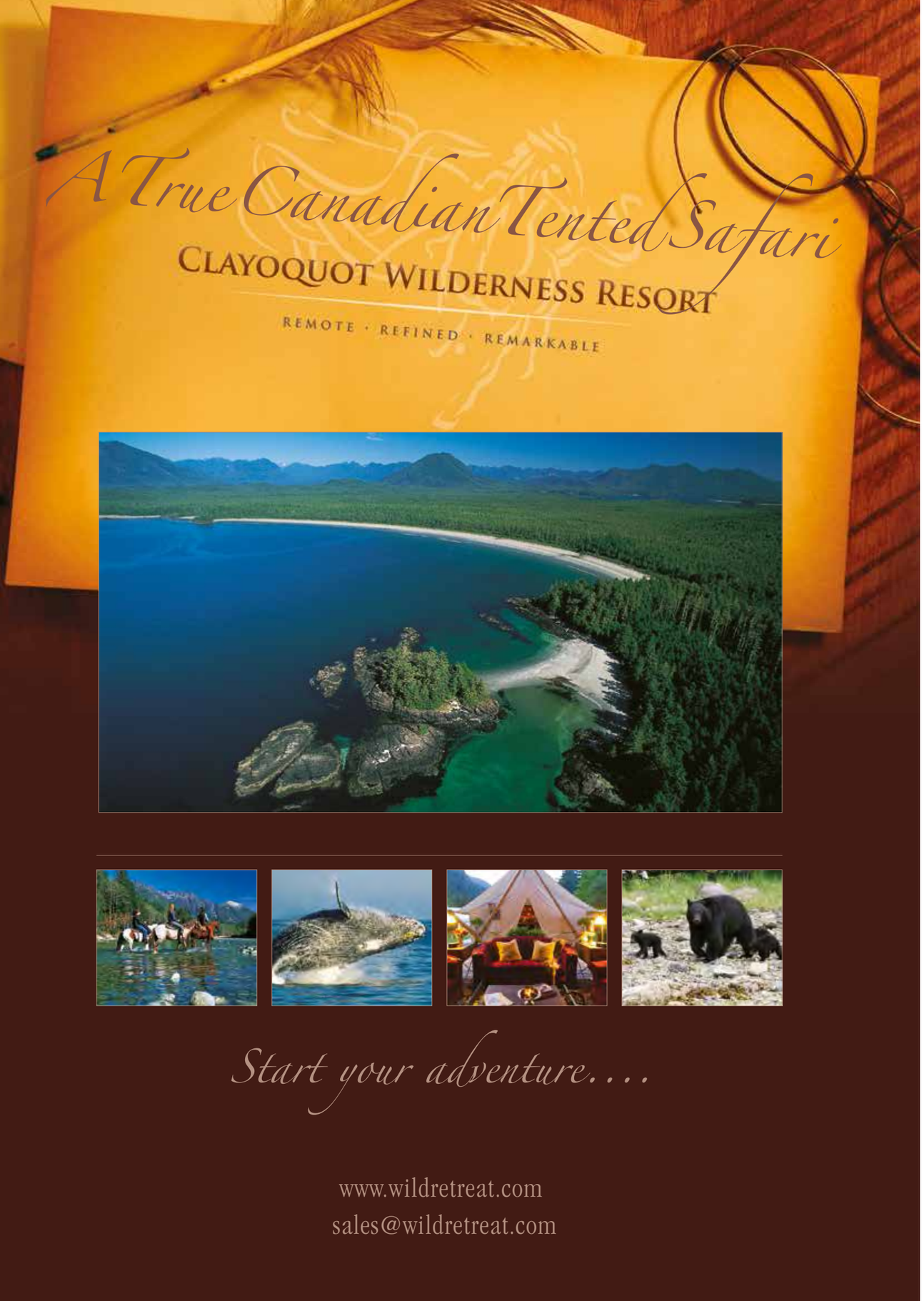

PURE AGENDA

PURE MICE EXPERIENCES · Marrakech Palais Des Congrès · 4th EDITION · 12-15 NOV 2012 · LONDON · MARRAKECH

Sunday 11th November 2012

12:00 - 18:00	Registration in the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi (NO ACCESS TO STANDS)

Monday 12th November 2012

12:00 - 15:00	Exhibitor access for stand decoration
15:00 - 15:30	Pre Conference Coffee
15:30 - 15:45	Entry to Conference Doors close promptly at 15.45
16:00 - 18:45	PURE 2012 'The Era of the Challenger Mindset' at Salles des Ministres, Palais des Congrès
20:00 - 00:00	PURE opening party at Selman Marrakech

Tuesday 13th November 2012

08:45	Doors open for PURE Life Experiences
09:00 - 18:00	Official opening hours
09:15	Morning appointments start
10:50 - 11:25	Networking break, refreshments courtesy of the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
12:35 - 13:45	Lunch at Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
14:00	Afternoon appointments start
15:35 - 16:15	Networking break, refreshments courtesy of the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
17:25	Last appointment of the day finishes
17:25 - 18:00	Free Networking
20:00	PURE Cocktail Party at Sofitel Palais Impérial, Marrakech
22:30 - 02:00	Argentine Night After Party at So Night Lounge, Sofitel, Marrakech

Wednesday 14th November 2012

08:45	Doors open for PURE Life Experiences
09:00 - 18:00	Official opening hours
09:15	Morning appointments start
10:50 - 11:25	Networking break, refreshments courtesy of the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
12:35 - 13:45	Lunch at Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
14:00	Afternoon appointments start
15:35 - 16:15	Networking break, refreshments courtesy of the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
17:25	Last appointment of the day finishes
17:25 - 18:00	Free Networking
18:00 Onwards	Free Evening

Thursday 15th November 2012

08:45	Doors open for PURE Life Experiences
09:00 - 17:45	Official opening hours
09:15	Morning appointments start
10:50 - 11:25	Networking break, refreshments courtesy of the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
12:35 - 13:45	Lunch at Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
14:00	Afternoon appointments start
15:35 - 16:15	Networking break, refreshments courtesy of the Hotel Mansour Eddahbi
17:25	Last appointment of the day finishes
17:25 - 17:45	Free Networking
20:00	Official PURE Farewell Party at Delano Marrakech

Above agenda is strictly for pre-registered members wearing their registration badge and PURE bracelet.
*Pick up points in front of the following hotels:
La Mamounia, La Sultana, Naoura Lucien Barrière, Selman, Royal Mansour, Sofitel Palais Impérial, Amanjena & Mosaic Palais Aziza.
Delano & Hivernage hotels: in front of Sofitel Palais Impérial
Es Saadi Hotel and Palace : in front of the Es Saadi Palace
Mansour Eddahbi, Ryad Mogador Menara, Atlas Medina: in front of the Mansour Eddahbi

THE PURE 2012 CONFERENCE

16.00– 18.45 Monday 12th November 2012
Salles des Ministres, Palais Des Congres

The Era of the Challenger Mindset

The juxtaposing notions of challenges and challenger brand thinking are ones that resonate throughout Experiential Travel - based on an attitude of overcoming challenges faced, along with those striving to do something unique within their space. Being a challenger brand is a mindset, one that intrudes on consumers' consciousness and thrives when underestimated. Being different is what sets challengers apart – through identity, emotion, intensity and salience.

As PUREists, we are the brands that challenge conventional travel. We pride ourselves on offering the very best of Experiential Travel – creating memorable and powerful experiences that will improve the way customers connect with loved ones and with the world. We are the brands that constantly challenge ourselves asking the 'what ifs' and the 'why nots', thinking and acting differently to create a bigger impact within our audience.

As the thought leaders in the industry it raises the question, how do we tackle the challenges faced in business and what does it really take to be a challenger brand? What challenger stances do we need to take to remain fresh and engaging with our customers? There is the need to disrupt the market and introduce new offerings and take on larger competition through innovation and imagination.

Constantly seeking to surprise and delight customers is one of the focal essences of Experiential Travel, and one that the PURE community excels at. One of the traits that many challenger brands, such as our PURE community share, is the ability to give a sense of the people behind our brands. Appealing to the consumer at a more personal level than market leaders, we firmly make a human-to-human connection becoming compelling characters within our consumers' lives.

However, when it comes to making an impact within the industry, evolving and driving sales, how do we, as the challenger brand, evolve and grow whilst staying true to PUREist roots of authenticity with a personal approach? What learnings do we take away from their strategies and apply to our high-emotion, experiential offering to sustain growth?

As with any industry, there are a number of challenges faced within Experiential Travel – from the direct competition, the economy, how to tackle communication channels through to ecological changes, conservation and personal challenges. Through identifying alternative ways of approaching these issues, we as entrepreneurial brand challengers will prosper. Standing out from the competition and challenging the norm with intensity through confidence in ourselves is an attitude; an entrepreneurial and inspirational attitude that differentiates us not only in the world of business, but also when faced with personal challenges. Strength of character and determination are the essence of a challenger. As Rudyard Kipling once said: "If you can meet with triumph and disaster and treat those two imposters just the same"

Challenges in the media landscape are also ones that impact Experiential Travel on a number of levels. Now, more than ever, there is the need to break-away from the cookie-cutter approach to media and marketing. Thinking laterally in terms of achieving quality editorial cut-through that will not only cement our brand positioning, but will further raise awareness of our profile with the consumer and the wider industry, ultimately helping to drive sales.

As the importance of independent respected voices becomes more valued, our attentions should be channelled on developing long-term, personal relationships with our customers in real-time. Everything we do, communicates our brand: from the way we interact with customers to the etiquette of our staff – it's no longer just traditional marketing media that does so. And that's why we need to continue evolving, structuring our communication approaches in a way that drives breakthrough.

Being a challenger is, put simply, a state of mind. The ability and the desire to think differently. Challenger brands nourish emotional relationships with their customers, building organic customer loyalty.

As a PUREist you reflect the action of challenger brand leaders. With your unique contributions along with your fellow industry visionaries, we once again aim to challenge you and your thinking on how to continue prospering as high-emotion PUREists.

Thank you for joining our adventure!

KEYNOTE SPEAKERS

Adam Morgan

Author and Founder of eatbigfish

"How challenger brands succeed"

Adam Morgan is the highly respected author of Eating The Big Fish: How Challenger Brands can compete against Brand Leaders', a seminal work in the world of branding. It not only coined the phrase Challenger Brand, but also outlined a process for doing more with less and whose principles have been widely praised and much imitated around the world. In 1997 Adam founded eatbigfish and established the Challenger Project, a research project into how challenger brands succeed across a variety of different categories. It's no exaggeration to say that his consultancy has created entirely new ways of thinking about both the development of distinctive brands but also the cultural conditions necessary to support them, reshaping how many large corporations have thought about structuring their businesses for success.

His ideas will challenge your habits and the formulas of the past, provide new ways to think about insight, sources of growth, and sources of meaning for modern businesses and the people who run them. In his speech Adam will address the fundamental questions of "What is a Challenger Brand?" and 'Why does a business need to act and think like a Challenger'?

Sir Ranulph Fiennes - Bt OBE

The World's Greatest Living Explorer

"Persistence, tolerance, fitness, agility – the ability to perform under extreme pressure"

Having recently announced a daring plan to walk across the Antarctic continent in the polar winter of 2013, in total darkness and in temperatures down to minus 90 degrees Celsius, it is no surprise that Ranulph Fiennes is described as 'the World's Greatest Living Explorer'.

Ran's record-breaking expeditions include seven marathons on seven continents in seven days – not long after receiving emergency heart surgery – travel by riverboat, hovercraft, manhaul sledge, skidoo, Land Rover and ski, and he is the only man alive on earth to have travelled round the Earth's circumpolar surface. And having taken up climbing, starting with the North Face of the Eiger at the age of 65, Ran became the oldest person to conquer Everest. When it comes to a challenger mind-set, Ranulph Fiennes is the embodiment of grit and the determination to overcome physical adversity.

Ran's inspiring stories draw a connection between nature's most dangerous and difficult challenges, and the day-to-day hurdles we all face. We may not risk our own lives in the same way, but all these qualities are equally important in less hazardous occupations.

Sir Tim Smit - KBE

Co-Founder Chief Executive of the Eden Project

"Keeping principles and meeting challenges head-on"

Having worked in the music industry for many years as a composer/producer in rock and opera, Tim Smit decided it was time for a project that would challenge all his business and creative knowhow. A move from the city to the wilds of Cornwall saw Tim devoting his time to restoring the Lost Gardens of Heligan. He is now known the world over as co-founder and Chief Executive of the groundbreaking, award winning Eden Project.

Eden began as a dream in 1995 and opened its doors just five years later - greeted by much of the press as 'the eighth wonder of the world.' Since then more than twelve million visitors have come to enjoy a once sterile pit turned into a cradle of life. It is both a showcase for world-class horticulture and an architectural symbol of human endeavor. Eden has also changed many people's perceptions of science, by communicating scientific concepts through art and storytelling.

Tim argues that the twin challenge of economic hardship and climate change makes it necessary to embrace the spirit of war – with a radical approach based less on choice and more on responsibility.

Panel Discussion: The Challenge of the Media; with traditional media in a state of flux, where is time and money best invested?

OUR EXPERT PANEL INCLUDES:

Andy Whiteside

PRCo Director of Digital Communications

Andy Whiteside, Director of Digital Communications at PRCo has forged a career that spans both sides of the PR track. Starting life in investigative journalism for national newspapers, becoming features writer on several magazines and holding the title of Editor at Axiom Publications in 1995, he then went on to develop a career in PR and Marketing, co-founding Gifted Productions in 2007. Passionate about travel, he grew up immersed in a family business of privately owned hotels and restaurants. In his years of travelling, Andy has amassed a wealth of knowledge about the hospitality sector. Andy is now responsible for the strategy and implementation of digital PR, social media and marketing campaigns for a wide range of clients including hotels, spas, destinations, international real estate and lifestyle brands at PRCo. This unique mix gives Andy a unique take on the use of PR, digital and content marketing.

Glen Donovan

Founder of EARTH.

Its remit is no more complicated than "selling places we love to people we like".

Glen's love of art, music and theatre – and his friends within these areas – is shaping the approach to the business of creating a travel company. Contrary to popular opinion EARTH's offerings aren't typically the most grand. Of course, they might be this too, but only if they have a charm, a level of discreet and efficient service and some sort of 'WOW' factor which may not always be immediately explicit. Obsessive attention to detail and a wanderlust that takes the team to extreme parts of the planet, means that EARTH is always evolving – never static.

EARTH is very much a proud British brand and based in central London.

The company restricted growth in 2003 by cancelling all press interviews and PR, and de-listing its telephone number.

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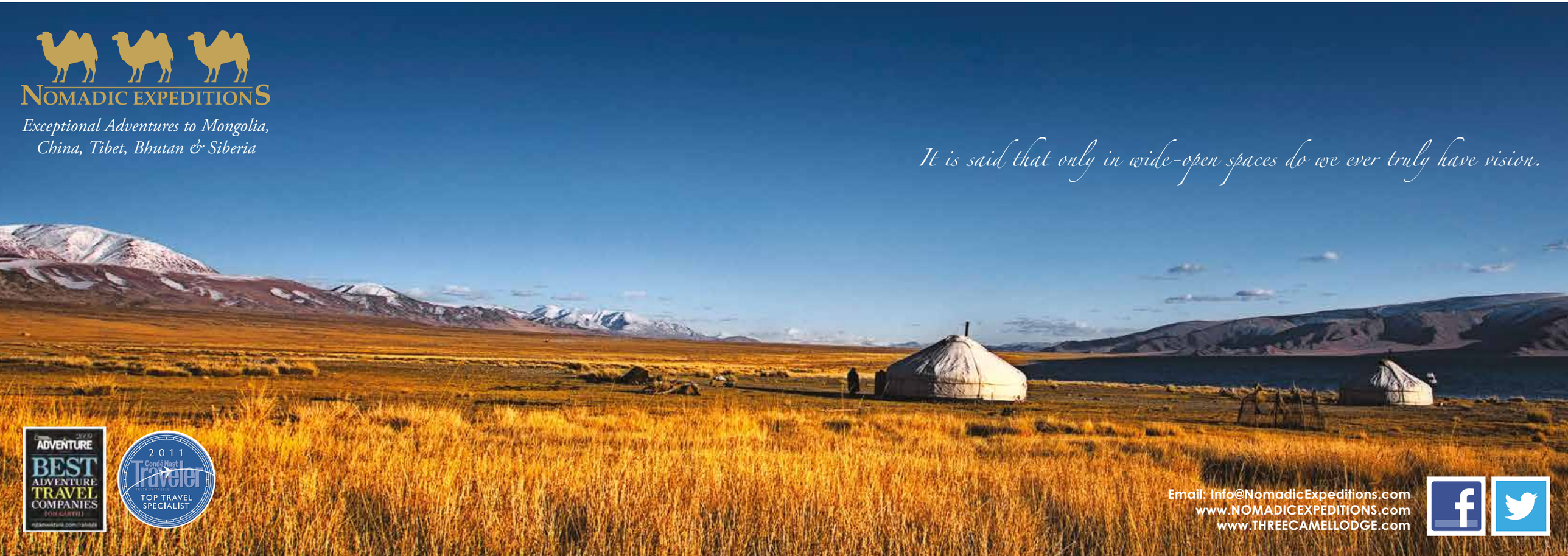
It is said that only in wide-open spaces do we ever truly have vision.



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www.NOMADICEXPEDITIONS.com
www.THREECAMELLODGE.com

Guy Dittrich

International Writer and Journalist

A freelance writer and independent commentator on hotels, travel and design Guy Dittrich frequently programmes, moderates and presents for both corporates (Bang & Olufsen, Villeroy & Boch, Philips) and at conferences (The Sleep Event, HI Design, Deutscher Hotel Kongress, Brussels Design Forum, Human Cities Biennale, Venuez Holland, Design Hotels™ Arena*). A long-term contributor to Wallpaper* and Condé Nast Traveller magazines, Guy also writes for Forbes, TTG Luxury and a variety of UK and European publications and travel websites. Additionally Guy writes for a wide range of hospitality-related businesses (The Future Laboratory, STR Global, Herman Miller, Delvaux, various hotels and tourist boards).

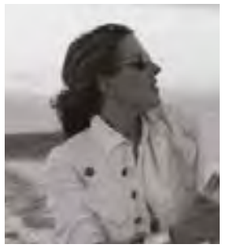
Born and raised in Zimbabwe and having lived in both London and Munich, Guy now works between London and Brussels. Prior to his career in writing and moderation Guy was the UK Managing Director for Design Hotels™.

Michael Doneff

President & Founder M Collective

Over the span of his 25-year career, Michael Doneff has made his mark through his work with some of the biggest names in the luxury lifestyle sphere. Through his entrepreneurial approach and instinctive skills, Michael has successfully spearheaded branding, marketing and communications for both up-and-coming companies and some of the world's most revered brands. Michael spent 14 years as a principal of the esteemed, New York-based Susan Magrino Agency, with clients such as One&Only Resorts, Michelin Guide, Dom Pérignon, Cooper Hewitt Museum, and the original brand launch of W Hotels.
In 2006, he became Vice President of Marketing for hospitality mavericks SBE and Viceroy Hotel Group, and most recently as Chief Marketing Officer of the iconic wellness company, Canyon Ranch. As the in-house marketing lead for these fast-growing companies, Michael played a pivotal role in creating, evolving and skillfully driving their brands to new heights.
In 2012, he formed M Collective to apply his wealth of experience and creative eye to a select list of clients. This wealth of knowledge sees Michael perfectly positioned to give comment on the marketing and PR mix.

Sophy Roberts



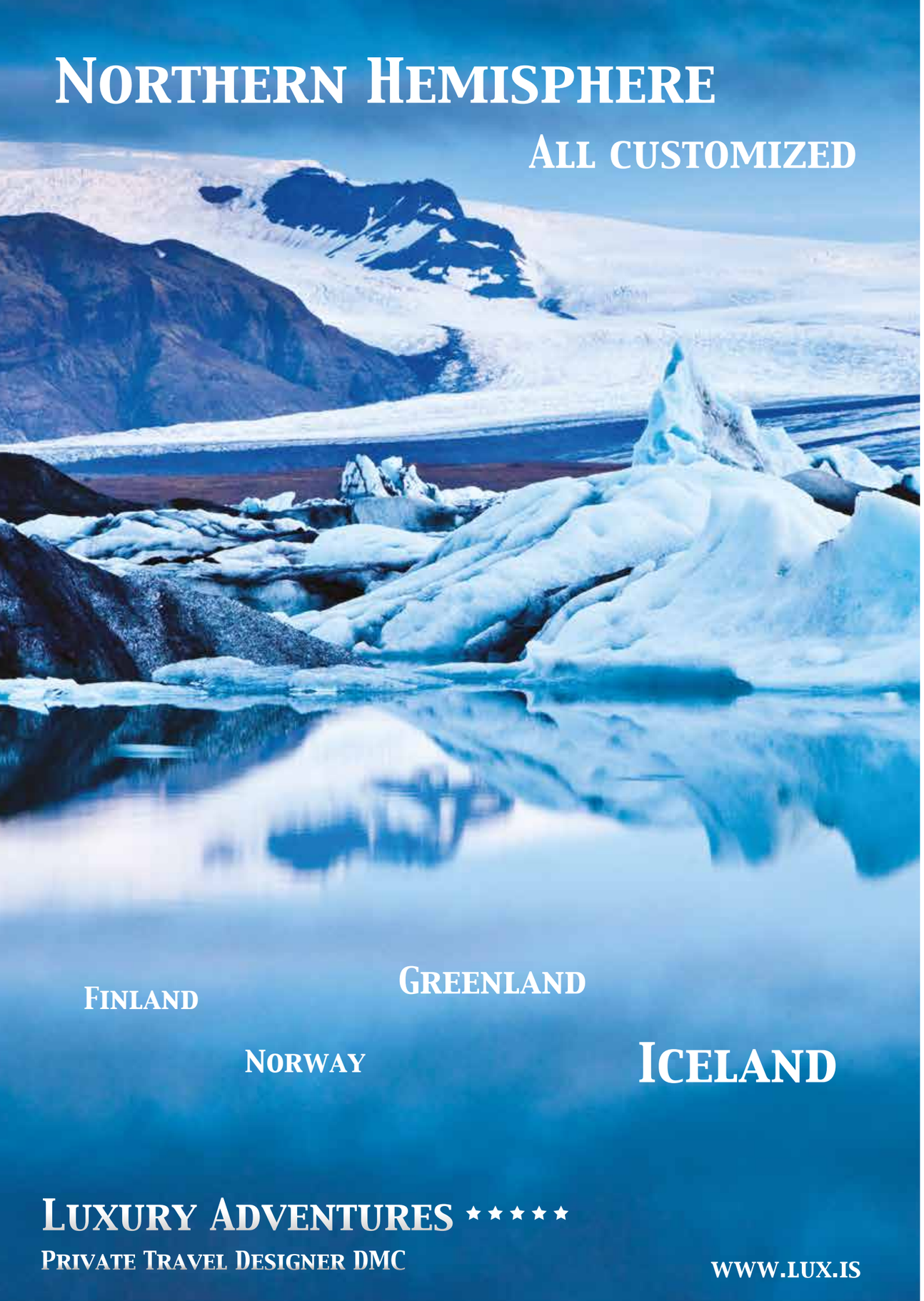
Travel Journalist, Editor and Founder of New Vellum

Sophy Roberts has covered the luxury market for over 15 years as an award-winning magazine editor, journalist and columnist. She regularly contributes to The Financial Times and Departures covering off-the-beaten track destinations. As the founder of New Vellum, a company providing editorial-style content for websites and online communications, Sophy also works with PURE Life Experiences as Editor in Chief of The Experientialist, a new travel magazine app.

Will Jones

Managing Director of Journeys By Design

An environmental scientist, Will was born in Africa and spent 25 years in six different countries in Africa before returning to the UK in 1999 to start Journeys by Design. Recently rated in the Top Ten 'super–agents' by the Financial Times, the niche travel company focuses exclusively on the continent he knows best - Africa.
What sets him apart is his extensive knowledge of Africa, his contacts, and his responsible tourism initiatives, including a business plan to develop tourism to Ethiopia. Jones designs private, individual trips for clients that change the way they look at the world; Ralph Lauren chose him to plan a safari for his family that Will privately guided.
Journeys by Design handles less than 200 clients a year to Africa, all at the very top end of the specialist, luxury safari market. With only 6 staff the company remains small, personal and focused on providing an unparalleled personal service. This attention to detail and obsession with creating the right trip for a select number of clients only also reflects Will attitude to how he interacts with the media.



PURE TRANSFERS

Sunday 11th November 2012

ALL DAY	Transfer Shuttle between Airport and Hotels*
12:00 - 18:00	Transfer Shuttle from Hotels* to Palais Des Congres for PURE registration

Monday 12th November 2012

ALL DAY	Transfer Shuttle between Airport and Hotels*
FROM 10:00	Hourly Transfer Shuttle between Hotel pick up points* and Palais des Congrès until conference
19:00	Transfer Shuttle between Palais des Congrès and Hotels*
20:00	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and the Official PURE Welcome Party at Selman Marrakech
22:00 - 24.00	Return Transfer Shuttle to Hotels*

Tuesday 13th November 2012

08:30	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and Palais des Congrès
18:00	Transfer Shuttle between Palais des Congrès and Hotels*
20:00	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and Official PURE Cocktail Party at Sofitel, Marrakech and Argentine Night After Party at So Night Lounge, Sofitel, Marrakech
22:30 - 02:00	Return Transfer Shuttle to Hotels*

Wednesday 14th November 2012

08:30	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and Palais des Congrès
18:00	Transfer Shuttle between Palais des Congrès and Hotels*

Thursday 15th November 2012

08:30	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and Palais des Congrès
18:00	Transfer Shuttle between Palais des Congrès and Hotels*
20:00	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and Official PURE Farewell Party at Delano, Marrakech
23:00-Onwards	Return Transfer Shuttle to Hotels*

Friday 16th November 2012

ALL DAY	Transfer Shuttle between Hotels* and Airport

*Pick up points in front of the following hotels:

La Mamounia, La Sultana, Naoura Lucien Barrière, Selman, Royal Mansour, Sofitel Palais Impérial, Amanjena and Mosaic Palais Aziza.
Delano & Hivernage hotels: in front of Sofitel Palais Impérial
Es Saadi Hotel and Palace : in front of the Es Saadi Palace
Mansour Eddahbi, Ryad Mogador Menara, Atlas Medina: in front of the Mansour Eddahbi

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MOROCCO,
OUTSTANDING NATURE

Sitting at the Northwestern tip of Africa and enjoying two sea fronts, Morocco boasts more than 3500 km of beautiful and contrasting coastline. This includes 500 km on the Mediterranean Sea and an extended Atlantic coastline that snakes to an end beyond the Straits of Gibraltar and marks a striking fusion of the Mare Nostrum and the Atlantic Ocean.

© The Moroccan National Tourist Office

Covering more than two thirds of Moroccan land, the mountains can reach souring heights with dramatic peaks that cross a threshold of 4000m. Marking the unspoiled beauty of the Moroccan desert, in the southern part of the country in the region of Erg Chebbi, a stretch of mesmerising sand dunes reaches up 200 meters to meet the stars. Beautiful plains stretch all over the Moroccan land with low plateaus, rivers, hills and fertile plains, allowing the farming of a wide variety of products.

With a moderate Mediterranean style climate, tempered by the ocean, the weather in Morocco is delightful (10-26). The splendour and the unexpected variety of the country offers many internationally known natural and manmade masterpieces that represent the exquisiteness of this land.

MOROCCO, A LIVING CULTURE AND UNIQUE HISTORY

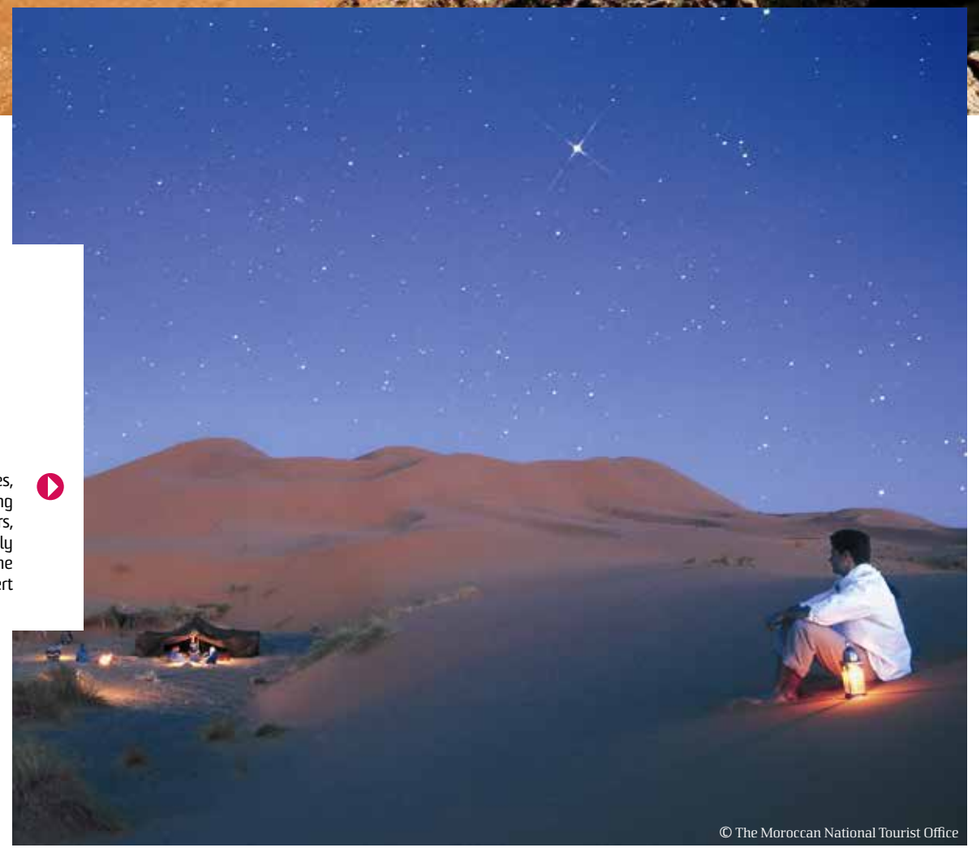
Morocco is seen as the meeting point of the African, Oriental and European worlds. A genuine melting pot of civilizations; the history of Morocco glows with prestige that is demonstrated through cultural and architectural influences, revealing the magnitude of the dynasties who have ruled through centuries of the country's history. The Idrissides, The Almoravids, The Merinids, The Saadiens up to The Alawites have all marked the history of the country and have left a priceless heritage. Cities like Fez, Meknes, Rabat or Marrakech embody the weightiness of the country's history and safeguard a culture of thousand years. The wonderful cultural exchange with Spain can be felt through the Arab-Andalusian styles, portrayed in various cities and UNESCO has recognised the world heritage significances of several sites. Morocco is where Gastronomy and crafts are central components of the culture.

MOROCCO, HOSPITALITY IS AN OLD TRADITION

The geographical location of Morocco has made it a target for various conquerors throughout history. The mixing of different cultures through centuries of history has made the Moroccans open-minded and tolerant people to whom hospitality comes naturally. Churches, Synagogues and Mosques standing side by side in perfect harmony in the alleys of the medina. "Sharing and Marhaba" (welcome) are the keywords of the Moroccan culture.

A surfer admires the beach in Agadir

Tranquility, clear skies, bright stars, shimmering vistas, intense colours, big dunes. Friendly Berber hospitality in the middle of the desert



© The Moroccan National Tourist Office

Berber music is well known for its use of folk oral traditions, as well as particular scales and rhythmic patterns, which include pentatonic music and African rhythms.

MOROCCO, AN EXCEPTION

At a time when most of the countries in the region are experiencing instability, Morocco marked a peaceful transition embracing a new constitution and persevering in its ambitious development policy aimed at enhancing the welfare of all its people.

MOROCCO, TOURISM IS ITS NATURAL ABILITY

Morocco is visited each year by almost 10 million tourists from around the world. It has a rich and varied offering to meet the expectations of the travellers in search of scenery, cultural immersion and relaxation, not to mention the wide variety of activities, which can be found in different regions of the country. The substantial development in infrastructure and the expansion of airlift has played an important role in the significant growth of the tourism industry of the country. Marrakech, Agadir, Fez, Tangier, Ouarzazate, Essaouira and Casablanca are examples of cities that now have become crests in the world of travel.

MARRAKECH, A HUB

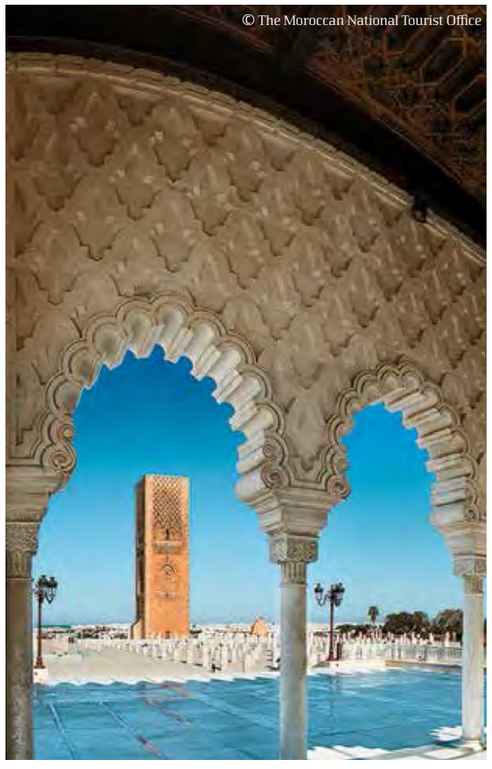
One of the most talked-about cities in recent years, Marrakech has become the destination for those interested in design, shopping and the naturally exotic. The centrepiece in what is widely regarded as North Africa's adventure playground; it has brought international sophistication to this dusty, dry corner of the world. Despite years of French occupation and a brisk trade in tourism, the city has maintained a sense of mystery and old-world charm not found anywhere else so close to Europe.

MARRAKECH, LIVING HISTORY

Almost a thousand years ago, this area, originally called Marra Kouch, was a meeting point between the vast stretches of the Western Sahara and the towering peaks of the Altas Mountains. In 1062, the Almoravids set up a central store of weapons and food at this strategic point of a caravan route used for the trading of gold and salt. From their new base, the Almoravids conquered the whole of Morocco and went on to land in Spain in 1086 and to eventually build an empire that stretched from Lisbon to Algiers. The sturdy city walls of Marrakech and the vast areas of palm groves that form the present day Palmeraie, to the north of the city, date from this era. The hundreds of pools and fountains find their origins in a complex underground irrigation system that used melted snow from the Atlas Mountains. The colourful gardens and abundance of vegetables owe much to the ingenious use of resources developed by the Almoravids.

MARRAKECH, THE JET SET

It was during the Swinging 1960s that Marrakech acquired its bohemian appeal, as the likes of Yves Saint Laurent, The Beatles, The Stones and Jean-Paul Getty all chose to hang out here. Over the ensuing decades increasing numbers of style conscious ex-pats came to the city to invest their money and design ideas, thus creating the mix of ancient tradition and modern chic that epitomizes the place today.



© The Moroccan National Tourist Office

The Mausoleum of Mohammed V is located on the opposite side of the Hassan Tower on the Yacoub al-Mansour esplanade in Rabat, Morocco. It contains the tombs of the Moroccan King and his two sons, late King Hassan II and Prince Abdallah.

© The Moroccan National Tourist Office

Dawn at the head of Imlil Valley, Imlil Valley is where most trekkers headout from for the highest peak, Toubkal

MARRAKECH ANCIENT MEETS MODERN

Its sophisticated riads, influenced and inspired by Islamic art but also by practical necessity, continue to captivate visitors with their luxurious, photogenic interiors and indulgent atmosphere. Meanwhile, the streets of the Medina remain relatively unchanged, providing a rare insight into the lives of ordinary Marrakchi and catapulting visitors back in time. The dust and heat of the Medina streets contrasts markedly with the relative sophistication and Westernization of Guéliz and other, newer, parts of the city.

MARRAKECH MODERN CHIC

There are many ways to spend a perfect day and night in the city. You could wander the ancient Medina streets in the morning, soaking up the bustling, ramshackle, pre-industrial atmosphere, hunting down some bargains and visiting a museum or Medersa. You could take a lunch break in one of the refined eateries that lie behind the Medina's dusty doors. Afterwards, head to Guéliz to check out an art gallery or treat yourself to some new clothes in the city's boutiques. In the evening, indulge in the full grandeur of the Moroccan dining experience at one of the palace restaurants, then take a refreshing mint tea at a café on the Jemaa el Fna and marvel at the nocturnal madness that has been unfolding in a similar way for the last thousand years. When the night is done, head back to your quiet, comfortable riad or hotel for a sound night's sleep, full of Arabian dreams.

MARRAKECH, BREATHTAKING SURROUNDINGS

If you feel the need to get out of the city, then there is a wealth of adventure options open to you. The High Atlas Mountains are a mere 40km from Marrakech – an hour's taxi ride will see you firmly ensconced among them. Here you can ride, trek, ski or simply soak up the purity of the air and inhale the natural aromas. In spring, wild flowers cover the mountainsides while in autumn the smells of the fruit harvest assail the senses.

A little further away you can begin to explore the edges of the Sahara. The desert is spectacular: its shape-shifting sand dunes and stunning rock formations will take your breath away. You can also make the most of this unique opportunity to observe the semi-nomadic lifestyles of the people who live here.

MOROCCO

Copy supplied by The Moroccan National Tourist Office

Jamaa el Fna The square is edged along one side by the Marrakech souk. Catering both for the common daily needs of the locals, and for the tourist trade. On other sides are hotels and gardens and cafe terraces offering an escape from the noise and confusion of the square.

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FROM SRINAGAR TO NUBRA

PHOTOGRAPHER FRÉDÉRIC LAGRANGE TRAVELS THE WORLD'S HIGHEST MOTORABLE ROAD PASS INTO BUDDHISM'S HEART

LOOKING BACK OVER THE SWITCHBACK ROAD LEADING INTO THE NUBRA VALLEY

THE FACES OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR REVEAL A CONNECTION TO CENTRAL ASIA

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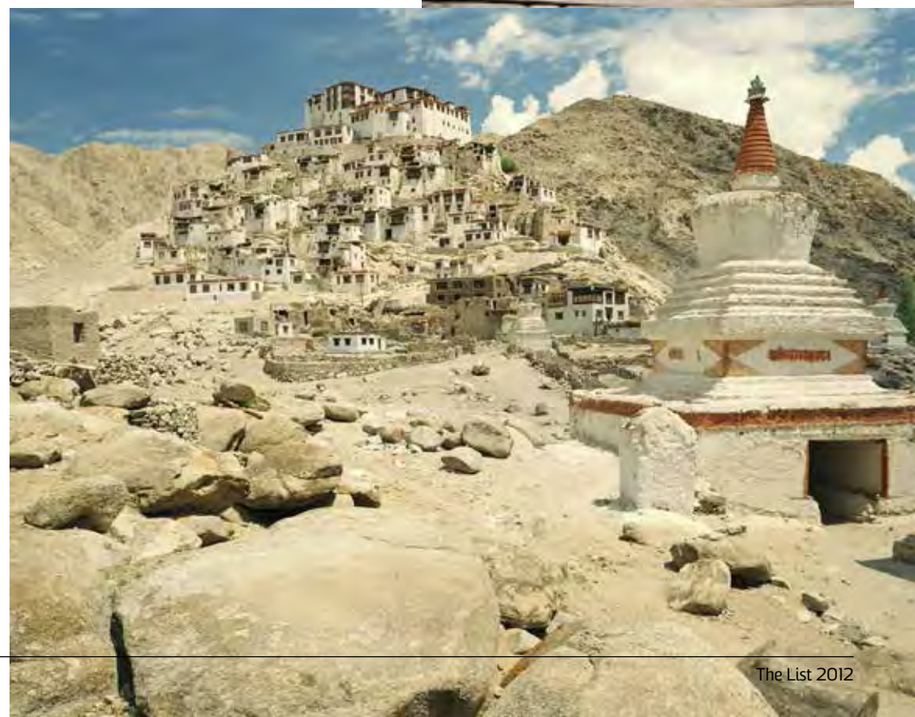
Jonny Bealby runs a London-based travel company called Wild Frontiers that specialises in 'difficult places'. Destinations range from Afghanistan's Wakhan Corridor—where I headed this summer—to Georgia's Caucasus Mountains. He casts his net wide, but still one of Jonny's most enduring attachments remains Kashmir in northern India where he first travelled in his early 20's.

The fact is only Jonny could have been fixing his plunge pool in the Hindu Kush when my travelling companion and I called to ask if he wanted to join us on a very particular road trip. A few weeks later and Jonny had it all sewn up: together we took a seven-day journey from Srinagar, the old summer hangout of the British Raj in India, to Nubra, a high-altitude desert in the shadow of the western Himalayas. We would travel along one of the world's highest roads on a newly widened two-lane highway.

With Jonny I was in the best possible hands, and this despite all the political forces at work in this tricky border territory. Indeed for the last two decades Srinagar has been largely off limits due to the city's proximity to the Line of Control that has formed India and Pakistan's contentious north-west border since 1949. Nubra isn't particularly straightforward, either. A moon-like valley a day's travel north of the Ladakhi capital of Leh, Nubra lies in the same politically charged state of Jammu and Kashmir; it is positioned in the same politically charged state of Jammy and Kashmir, close to the Line of Control. Hence the military convoys that traverse the highest roadpass in the world, Khardung La, at 5,602 metres. There is, after all, only one overland supply route to the Siachen Glacier, a vast tongue of ice beyond the far end of the Nubra Valley where thousands of Indian soldiers are currently deployed—and where earlier this year, on April 7th, a giant avalanche buried 124 Pakistani soldiers and 14 civilians, raising the question if territory this remote is really worth fighting for.

These are my photographs—a journal that takes in the serenity of the old summer capital on Dal Lake encircled by the snow-tipped Pir Pinjal mountains. I wanted to document the people and places we passed along the way, travelling from an ancient Islamic stronghold—Kashmir is 95 per cent Muslim—into 'little Tibet' with the poetic, crumbling monasteries full of Ladakh's Buddhist faithful. But this is just the beginning of a journey, says Jonny, who fixed the drivers, permits and hotels on our trip. One day he wants to go further and travel through Nubra into Baltistan and Central Asia's heartland. Knowing Jonny, he will be the first across the border—and I want to be the one who goes with him when that recce trip happens.

DAL LAKE, SRINAGAR, AT THE FOOT OF THE PIR PINJAL MOUNTAINS



LITTLE TIBET: LADAKH AND NUBRA ARE PEPPERED WITH BUDDHIST MONASTERIES

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A LOCAL ON THE ROADSIDE NEAR GILGIT, BETWEEN SRINAGAR AND LEH

From Delta to Desert

Photo: C. Ferreira / D. Luck

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SUSAN EASTON

Founder, FROM THE ROAD

Forever a driving force in her personal life, experiential travel is now shaping the way that Susan Easton does business. She recently founded FROM THE ROAD, a retail brand born out of her love for remote travel, design, indigenous cultures and their time-honored techniques. Susan traverses the globe to collaborate with artisans on limited edition decorative accessories for self and home that celebrate the source and help to sustain local art forms.

With 40+ countries in her travelogue, Susan has perfected the art of going off the grid. "When I travel, I like be immersed in the culture, which is why I frequently seek out a local translator or guide. Striking up conversations with people from the area has transformed so many of my travel experiences." In addition to enhancing her normal trips, such on-the-ground counterparts have proven essential on her more challenging ones. "In 2010, I set out to follow a portion of the Silk Road and as part of the trip, decided to visit a master artisan felt rug maker in the remote mountain town of At-Bashy, Kyrgyzstan. While en route to Janyl's home, I spotted what I thought was a weekly market; however, it was actually the beginnings of a major political uprising that resulted in coop". She never could have gotten through that experience without the help of her translator and the generosity of a local host – who sheltered her for four days, before she was smuggled out of the country to Uzbekistan just as the border was being closed down.

Despite her rugged and remote preferences while working, Susan often finds that luxury boutique hotels are the best entrée to experiential travel. "Good hotels provide access, connection, and those indispensable details that leave a lasting impression." She isn't afraid to ask for a personalized itinerary, a guide, even an archaeologist or an art broker. While in Bhutan, Susan took advantage of her resorts local connections to explore traditional medicine and indigenous "spa" treatments. The highlight after a long day of identifying therapeutic properties of the indigenous flora and fauna was a restorative outdoor hot stone mineral bath. "They arranged for me to visit a local family, skilled in this bath tradition, where they were literally warming stones on an open fire to heat a giant tub of water in their barn. Being outside, in their space, felt magical." And while in China's Yunnan Province, Susan's hotel arranged for a visit to remote village where bespoke teas were harvested and processed. "Teas are like wine in that region. You can order an incredibly expensive cup, but without the context, it's hard to understand what makes it truly special."

Her experiences are vast: from trekking to a nunnery in Tibet, observing gorillas in Rwanda to summiting a 18,000 ft volcano in the Atacama Desert. She is happiest when traveling alone so she can take in the experience more fully and has learned to make the most of unexpected detours – after all, "Travel snafus often become the highlight when I let go and just enjoy the whatever the moment brings." Next on her list? Northern Kenya to collaborate with artisans from a remote tribe known for their rustic bead work. And someday, Mongolia in a yurt, of course.

TRAVEL CURATOR TASTEMAKERS

The Travel Curator Tastemaker series gathers the Experiential Travel lowdown from notable globetrotters who travel for work, pleasure and the love of the unknown. Ranging from a filmmaker to the founder of an ethical cosmetics company, the Tastemakers are intrepid, creative and above all else, curious to explore the world's most far-flung corners

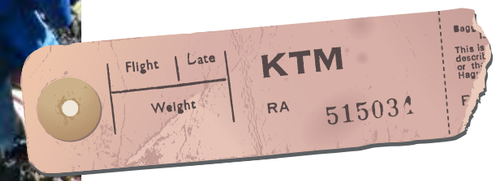
VAN NEISTAT

Filmmaker, Artist

In his work, Van Neistat takes a hands-on approach — be it experimenting with editing techniques for his films or building elaborate sets for artist Tom Sachs, everything he does has a meticulously start-from-scratch quality. The way Neistat travels is no different. Roaming freely with little else but a camera, Neistat has journeyed to the far corners of the globe — by plane, motorbike, or foot — to shoot and produce rich, experiential films for brands such as Nike and Tory Burch, each showcasing the world's most curious and magical realms. "The majority of my adventures are rooted in creative opportunities," enthuses Neistat, who splits time between Los Angeles and New York but is always on the job in one way or another.

While in production for his 2010 HBO show, The Neistat Brothers — which he wrote, starred in and filmed alongside brother Casey — Neistat scaled Mount Kilimanjaro, documenting the days-long summit on a tiny pocket camera that symbolically ran out of battery power on the descent, marking the end of the journey's arduous shoot. Before Kilimanjaro, Neistat and his crew spent ample time on a reserve in Tanzania, where he saw wild animals up close — including the elusive, endangered black rhino — and then in Zanzibar, where he slept in rustic bungalows by the beach and built campfires to cook fish caught that day by local fishermen. Of his experiences shooting the TV show, Neistat is ever grateful: "To have this travel budget and see the world, yet still manage to shoot everything so inexpensively and the way we wanted to, was incredible."

When journeying to somewhere new, Neistat prefers to find his footing in the actual destination and through a network of collaborators. This spontaneity has led to some of his best adventures, like the time he and Sachs rode around Salzburg on motorbikes — a modern-age take on film classic The Sound of Music — or the months when he lived in Berlin, installing Sachs's exhibition "NUTSY'S" at the Guggenheim and uncovering a hidden pocket of the city every day. Neistat's ability to extract wonder from his surroundings informs the sensibility of both his work and travels. "I try not to get caught up in the routine, the bills and the schedules — I'm blessed to live very simply and freely. I pay attention to the people around me and take the opportunities presented to me, and it all seems to lead to magic."



SUE DEVITT

Founder, SUE DEVITT BEAUTY

As a native Australian, Sue Devitt's passion for Oz's natural splendor is evident in all aspects of her holistic, nutrient-rich cosmetics brand, Sue Devitt Beauty. For years, Devitt has traveled the world as an in-demand make-up artist, giving her breathtaking access to several of its most remote locales and a true appreciation for dynamic landscapes, from lush rainforests to the barren tundra. Aside from stunning natural sights — which deeply influence the palettes of her beauty lines, not to mention the indigenous ingredients used in them — Devitt's treks are inspired by a variety of sources, from publications like Travel + Leisure, AFAR, VOGUE Entertaining + Travel and delicious magazine (an Aussie travel magazine for foodies) to popular TV programs such as Anthony Bourdain: No Reservations and Richard Wiese: Born to Explore. "Beauty is an apt metaphor for travel, as they're both incredibly transformative and take you to interesting destinations," notes Devitt, whose professional mantra is "Beauty is an adventure." Devitt's enriching travels — carried out by camel, motorbike or mokoro — are the foundation of her brand, its exquisite and ethical products appealing to women of all ages and ethnicities.

CYNTHIA ROWLEY

Designer, Art Enthusiast

From surfing off the coast of the Dominican Republic to trekking up Machu Picchu, Cynthia Rowley — head of the eponymous fashion empire, which produces everything from womenswear to handbags and even art-inspired Band-Aids — is as intrepid a traveler as they come. Her most adventurous trip? A journey to Tibet in the late '80s, shortly after the exotic and still elusive region first began welcoming Western travelers. Rowley spent three weeks driving, camping and hiking the intimidating terrain, traversing Llasa and eventually reaching Kathmandu, Nepal. "Tibet was a very unfamiliar place with stunning landscapes that I had never experienced before or have done since, just completely out of my world," says Rowley, who today calls New York's West Village home. "I was fascinated with Buddhist culture and loved seeing its monasteries, and of course experiencing the Tibetan Himalayas. It was the kind of trip I never could have anticipated; it evolved completely from its conception to finale. "Other highlights included getting to know the Tibetan people — "some of the warmest, most beautiful beings I've ever met" — and observing the level of detail and care in Tibetan design and craftsmanship, which Rowley honors in her own work, its thoughtful statement pieces spanning colorful knits to bold jewelry.

A passionate traveler, Rowley has built unique memories all over the world. Next on Rowley's horizon are journeys to the great unknowns — Cuba, Burma and Bhutan. "I'm interested in places beyond the scope of what's mainstream, these incredible frontiers with a strong character all of their own," says Rowley. A big believer in family travel, Rowley fuels her two daughters' curiosity about the world by planning active, far-flung trips wherein inspiring cultural experiences are front and center. Their next adventure? "Hopefully conquering the swells of Chile on a surf trip!"

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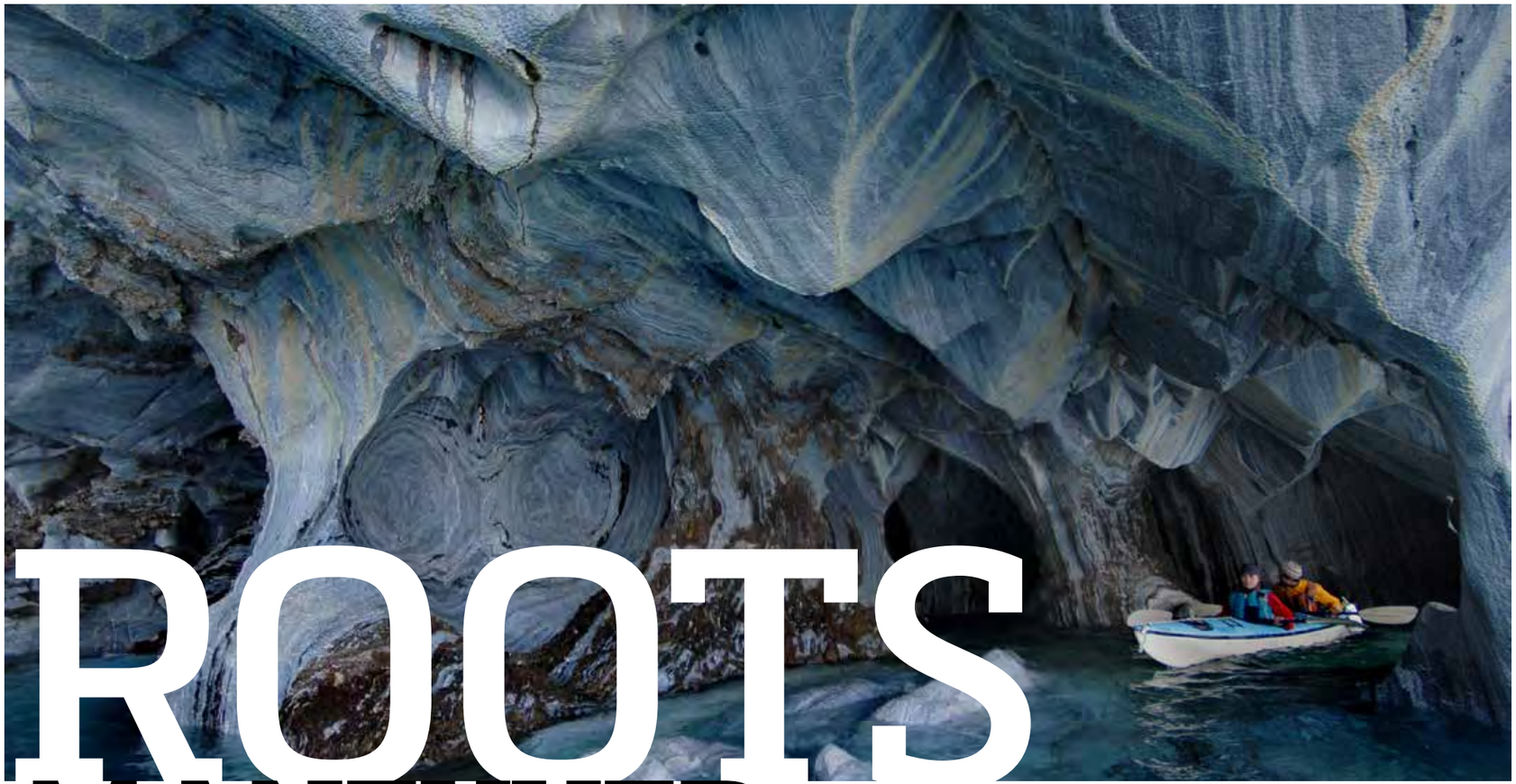

ROOTS MANEUVER

Kayaking - Cueva de Marmol, Chile the breathtakingly beautiful marble caves

The notion of adventuring to the earth's wildest places has obsessed the human species of our plant for time immemorial. This inherent need to seek and conquer the unknown has inspired travellers from Stanley to Scott and continues to evoke the modern-day explorer who travels with intention of facing a personal challenge, be it a cultural immersion or physical exertion; following a path that conjures the sensation of virgin territory underfoot. Staying in a bay leaf palm adobe in the Baining villages of Papua New Guinea or trekking across the Pirit Hills of the Antarctic may not replete with the kind of mortal dangers Livingstone faced in Africa or Amundsen in the South Pole – due to the lack of our modern day support networks - but does require the same gritty sprit embodied by those early pioneers. Todays experiential travellers have a curiosity for unfamiliar walks of life, environmental remoteness and an appetite to learn more about the diversity of this planet. They strive to achieve empathy, perspective, unique experiences and diverse challenges from travel; discovering a track untouched by commerciality is how they expect to accomplish this. The great travellers of early 20th Century were criticised as selfish for seeking personal gains from lengthy experiences and explorations. We can and should be just as selfish. These awe-inspiring images encapsulate and celebrate the enduring passion for adventure and cultural exploration that is embedded in the roots of our human history.

Words and images courtesy of PINCH Magazine.

PINCH was created to explore the connection between travel and peoples' passions and lifestyle choices. At the heart of it is the recognition that very often it is our other loves that move us to get on the road.

pinch-magazine.com

Tribes of West Papua

The Dani tribe, from the central highlands of West Papua

Himba man, in Northern Kunene region Namibia

Untouched off piste powder in Lyngen Alps, Norway

Camping and expedition training in Iceland

Desert journeys, Sinai Peninsula in Egypt

Fresh tracks, quad biking in Jordan

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The Divers Holy Grail

Three spurts of cold water at irregular intervals. That was it. A single, defiant offering from a shower that oozed remoteness and little else. I revelled in it. After flying all the way to Borneo, taking an internal flight, a one-hour car drive with a cavalier taxi driver and a 40km white knuckle boat ride across the Celebes Sea through a storm, somehow it wouldn't have seemed right to arrive at a high-end retreat without also finding different kind of creature comfort - the underwater kind. Finally I was going to dive Sipadan, the Holy Grail for scuba divers.

A tiny oceanic island off the east coast of Borneo's Sabah in East Malaysia, Pulau Sipidan sits on top of a large sea mountain extending over 600m down to the ocean floor. The island itself is a true paradise covered in palm trees and fringed with white, deserted beaches. Just a stone's throw from the sand, the pale waters over the sandy seabed change abruptly to a deep blue where the wall reef begins. Teeming with more seafans and black soft and hard corals than you could ever imagine, this vast wall reef plays host to fish of all colours of the rainbow.

Given its mid-ocean position, Sipadan is also frequented by many pelagics cruising along the reef walls - hundreds of schools of barracudas, manta rays, hammerhead and reef sharks and an army of both green and hawksbill turtles. With its 12 dive sites, it really is no wonder that the esteemed Jacques Cousteau declared Sipadan an 'untouched piece of art'.

Since 2000, the Malaysian government has imposed dive limits to preserve the eco-system, allowing permits for only 120 divers per day. If not booked in advance, these can be hard to obtain, however it does make the diving experience all the more special for those lucky few who make the cut.

Like most divers, I had come here in search of encounters with the big fish and I certainly wasn't disappointed. Out in the blue, while hovering on my back, I watched two enormous schools of barracudas loom into tornado-style formations, for what seemed an eternity. They were so large that the beaming day's sunlight was completely blocked out. Tens of metre-long grey reef sharks swam lazily past me, gathering in groups of threes.

But above all, let's be truthful, Sipadan's main attraction is its turtles. Diving in various locations across the world I have seen some beautiful turtles, but never so many all at once. On one dive alone I counted more than 20 - a mixture of both green and hawksbill. Nestled amongst the coral or rubbing an itchy spot against a rock, they gracefully made their way at steady intervals to the surface for a breather. Turtles glide slowly and elegantly through the water; being able to swim alongside one, matching their pace without inspiring fear is truly magical. One hawksbill was happily chomping on some soft coral along the reef wall. Steadying myself in the current, I hovered nearby and watched as this docile reptile dined. Though seemingly unfazed by my presence, after a short while I chose to give him some privacy - after all, no one likes to be watched when they're eating.

Sipadan's sheer profusion and diversity of life astounded me. There truly is nowhere better to experience all that the ocean has to offer.

Words by Daniela Marchesi, a diver, writer and adventurer.

Images provided by Jason Isley, Managing Director of Borneo based underwater production/publication company Scubazoo.

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- Enjoy a horseback ride at dusk on a beach

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The TRAVEL CURATOR GUIDE

Renowned for its flavourful eats, variety of treasures and one-of-a-kind finds offered in its winding bazaars, and vibrant nightlife scene, Morocco's crown jewel, Marrakech, boldly straddles the line between old and new in remarkable style. Listing her top places to explore — from the most atmospheric dining spots to festive bars and expertly stocked boutiques — Melanie Brandman, The Travel Curator, shares her best Marrakech finds so that you can navigate the city like a local.

EAT PLAY SHOP

Al Fassia

Located in the popular Gueliz neighborhood (see Shopping), this is considered a Marrakech classic, as much for its authentic dishes as for the fact that it's managed exclusively by women, evoking a homegrown, family-run vibe. Over its 20 years of operation, Al Fassia is celebrated for its superb cuisine — everyone raves about the pigeon, but make sure you leave room for dessert. Unlike most Moroccan restaurants, the portion sizes are not overwhelming; you can order as little or as much as you like.

55 Boulevard Zerktouni, Gueliz.
Tel: 00 212 24 43 40 60
www.alfassia.com

Le Grand Café de la Poste

This former 1920s post office is now a popular brasserie attracting local tastemakers and jetsetters. It's been restored to its colonial glory (think rattan, palm trees and ceiling fans), giving it a laid-back and friendly vibe. A great place for all-day dining, it's easy to relax here — I'm a big fan of their pre-and post-dinner cocktails, especially. The food is surprisingly good: traditional French brasserie fare, with a Moroccan twist.

Corner of bd. El Mansour Eddahbi and av. Imam Malik, Gueliz.
Tel: 00 212 5 24 43 30 38
www.grandcafedelaposte.com

Dar Yacout

This chic landmark restaurant is one of my favorites — a must for both first-time and repeat visitors to Marrakech. Albeit a bit over the top, the restaurant is high on design and has been the inspiration for Moroccan interiors since it opened 20 years ago. Housed in a gorgeous riad in the Medina, it's a bit of a rabbit warren trying to find it (have a guide help you), but well worth the effort. It features beautiful room upon beautiful room, and the main dining room is straight from a film set. Don't miss the rooftop terrace for stellar views over the medina. The cuisine is traditional Moroccan and reservations are a must.

79 Derb Sidi Ahmed Soussi.
Tel: 00 212 44 38 29 29

Le Tobsil

Considered one of the most romantic restaurants in Marrakech — not to mention one of the most popular — Le Tobsil is regarded as a more intimate version of Dar Yacout. Its allure stems from its traditional architecture, candlelit arches and the richness of its Persian rugs. Located in the medina, this beautifully renovated former mansion offers a daily prix fixe of Moroccan dishes using the freshest market produce. Favorites include the couscous and tagine selections. Fantastic restaurant for vegetarians, in particular — it's easy to get full on Le Tobsil's vegetable meze dishes alone.

22 Derb Moulay Abdellah Ben Hassaien,
R'mila Bab Ksour, Medina.
Tel 00 212 5 24 44 40 52

La Terrasse des Épices

This is one of my favorite restaurants in the medina and a perfect spot to perch after shopping in the souk. The rooftop terrace is the place to be and it's easy to settle in after a light and delicious lunch. This accessible restaurant offers a good range of dishes, from the traditional Moroccan salad, a selection of grills and pasta to a tempting array of desserts. In the evening, the glow from low-hung lights makes it a great place to relax for a casual dinner.

15 Souk Charifia, Sidi Abdellaziz, Medina.
Tel: 00 212 524 37 59 04
www.terrassedesepices.com

PLAY

Bo-Zin

My favorite chic watering hole in Marrakech — fantastic atmosphere and international scene, on full display in the breathtaking outdoor terrace. I'm a big fan of the eclectic music here, spanning everything from Billie Holiday to the latest Euro DJ outfit. On top of it all, the delicious cocktails make the whole experience go down easy — just let the bartender know what your preferred poison is so they can fix you up with something special. The small plates are also worth a nibble, especially the Mechoui lamb.

Douar Lahna, Route de l'Ourika,
tel: 00 212 5243 88012
www.bo-zin.com

Le Comptoir

The vision of proprietor Marcel Chiche, Paris nightlife legend. This restaurant-club blends Eastern and Western influences seamlessly. This is a definite "paint the town red" kind of establishment — and everything in here, from the décor to the lighting, is literally red. A good mix of international travelers, discerning locals and the usual business folks. The bar is always good for a strong cocktail or occasional belly dancing performance. Definitely for those seeking a vibrant nightlife experience in Marrakech, although the staff is always personable.

Avenue Echoulada
tel: 00 0524 437 702
www.comptoirmarrakech.com

Lotus Club

This place is very popular with the locals, which is always a good sign. The décor at Lotus is endlessly entertaining — lots of great art and installations throughout the space, very Andy Warhol. I like that this very stylish club is a bit out of the way; it gives it a hidden gem feel, and the warm staff — from the gorgeous waitresses (all of whom speak several languages) and in-the-know bartenders — makes everyone feel like a VIP. The playlist here is very fun — contemporary hits mixed in with oldies and even some very intriguing world music selections. I can't say I've ever had an off night here.

Rue Ahmed Chaouqi, Hivernage
tel: 00 212 5 24 42 17 36
www.riadlotus.com

Palais Jad Mahal

Located in Marrakech's always-buzzy Hivernage district, the Palais is a great choice for a splashy night out on the town. As the regal name might indicate, it's quite a festive place — a mix between Morocco and Mumbai. I prefer to meet with friends at the lounge and enjoy a drink over live music before heading onward to a fabulous restaurant — although you can get good bites here, too, namely the curries and chicken tagine. Don't miss one of the nightly dance performances: over-the-top in the best possible way.

10 Rue Houroune Errachid, Hivernage
tel: 00 212 5 24 43 69 84
www.jad-mahal.com

Le Djellabar

I love the pop-art design of this sleek lounge-club, also in the trendy Hivernage area. For a nightlife establishment, it's more on the quieter, happy hour side — good for bonding over cocktails and small bites in the French Moroccan vein (for the perennial sweet tooth in me, the spicy chocolate Tarbouche cake is a must). I love the flattering purple-pink lighting and very cool Oriental pop art on the walls. Djellabar provides the signature Marrakech stimulation without being too overwhelming.

Villa Bougaivillee, 2 Rue Abou Hanifa, Hivernage
tel: 00 212 5 24 42 12 42
www.djellabar.com

SHOP

Atika

I always suggest to my friends visiting Marrakech to start their shopping with a visit to Atika, a fantastic shoe store in the popular Guéliz area. While it may not appear like much from the outside, inside is a treasure trove of shoes in every color of the rainbow. Most popular are their "Tod"-style loafers, in women's and men's sizes. From Prada and Hermes- esque sandals to belts and handbags, it's difficult not to leave Atika loaded with bags.

34 Rue de la Liberté, Guéliz

33 Rue Majorelle

Located in another up and coming shopping area in front of the entrance to the famous Jardin Majorelle is this terrific concept store. I'm always impressed by its great selection of fashion and design pieces from Moroccan designers, including my favorite Noureddine Amir. When your shopping is done — or even before it starts — have a freshly-pressed orange juice at the little café on the corner of this design block.

Rue Yves Saint-Laurent
www.33ruemajorelle.com

Atelier Moro

One of my best finds in the Medina is Atelier Moro, owned by Colombian-born designer Viviana González. Fantastic for picking up chic and functional gifts to take home, the shop has an eclectic mix of locally made accessories such as pictures frames, embroidered cotton caftans and furniture. I particularly love the striped silver coffee spoons.

114 Place de laFontaine, Medina

Galerie Birkemeyer

Now with two stores — one in the popular Guéliz neighborhood and another across from Jardin Majorelle— it's hard not to drop in and drool over the fantastic selection of designer-inspired handbags and leather jackets. If they don't have want you want, they will always make it to order and ship anywhere in the world. Convenient luxury.

169-171, Rue Mohamed El Beqal
www.galerie-birkemeyer.com

Scènes de Lin

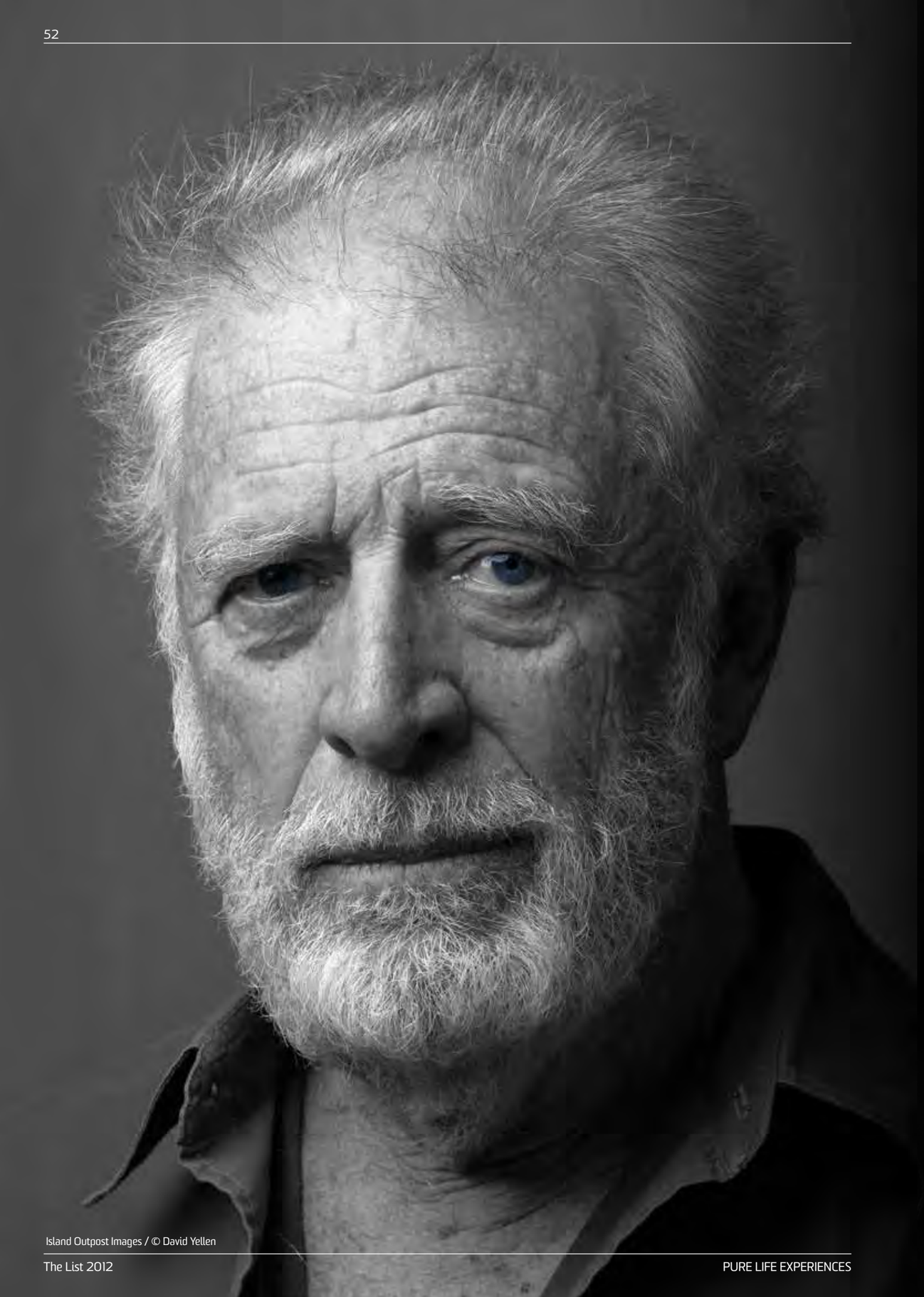
On Rue de Liberté is this super stylish home furnishings store — one of my favorites. I have stocked up on their exquisite lines and beautifully stitched bed and table linens, sold by the yard. Add gorgeous leather desks and writing accessories to the mix and you have a chic, discerning home-office at the ready!

34 Rue de la Liberté, Guéliz
www.scenesdelin.com

The Travel Curator is founder Melanie Brandman's latest venture, a high-end travel website offering readers an expert's opinion on the world's most inspiring destinations. Designed to cut through the clutter, the fun to flip through site affords access to her tried and tested favorites, the latest travel trends, and word-of-mouth travel tips from her globetrotting friends.

Being Australian, Melanie has a natural fascination with and desire to travel – for Aussies, it's a rite of passage. Today, as CEO of The Brandman Agency, her high-end travel PR firm, and founder of The Travel Curator, her travel schedule is endless; on average, she is on the road internationally anywhere between 10 and 14 days a month.

Melanie is a trusted, go-to person because wherever she is, she is always scouting out the most interesting and exciting things that the destination has to offer.



Island Outpost Images / © David Yellen

The Experientialist
Available on the App Store

Chris Blackwell
founder of Island Outpost

Sophy Roberts travels to Jamaica to meet Chris Blackwell—music producer, hotelier and island ambassador—to understand how one man has made it his mission to make the world rethink Jamaica by believing in the soul of a place more than imported concepts of 'globalised luxury'

Chris Blackwell's home in the Cockpit Mountains in Jamaica is not as I expected—a modest two-floor structure built from old Portland stone once used as ballast. It has a wide verandah packed with comfortable chairs, flowering climbers and a backgammon board, the house positioned in the middle of a grassy plateau punctuated with a few wide-canopied trees. Yet Blackwell is one of the giants of the music industry—the founder of record label Island Records that went on to get snapped up by Polygram in 1992 for a reported £272 million. I assumed he'd live like others in his industry—in profligate style—yet instead I spend the last 20 minutes of our journey being thrown around the car. The road to his house is in a bad way, washed by the Jamaican rains; in truth it doesn't look like it has been fixed in a while. The fencing on either side of the track is also in a pretty sorry state—good enough to keep Blackwell's white Brahmin cattle from wandering too freely, but again, hardly the tidy post-and-rail with electric gates one might expect from the music superstar this man really is.

But then Blackwell is defined by his quietly confident, maverick style. He isn't into showmanship, even if show business is what now consumes the 'Pop Idol'-obsessed industry circa 2012. When I walk into Blackwell's home, his maid isn't cooking dinner. He is—a chicken broth served with a good, simple wine. I pinch myself in order to be reminded of Blackwell's context and successes, that this man more than anyone has helped tell Jamaica's story for the last 50 years, from the export of Bob Marley's 'One World, One Love' message to every corner of the earth to his very present endeavours with his Island Outpost group of hotels. I have to remind myself of the fact Blackwell has worked with nearly every major artist of the second half of the twentieth century and beyond, from Steve Winwood to U2. Then there's the privileged background to consider: born in 1937, Blackwell enjoyed a high society childhood on Jamaica, hanging out with the likes of Bond author Ian Fleming and Noël Coward; he was educated (and expelled) from the elite English boarding school of Harrow while his mother's family, the Lindos, were once among the island's biggest landowners. All this glamour, yet there he is serving soup to a group of three friends and a wrong-footed journalist. "Most people in big business live in stratas," he later remarks: "The great thing about the record business up until the 1970s was how people in music had very humble beginnings. I was working with people from the street. Or rather, I was working for them."

The Experientialist
Available on the App Store

It's a rare person who acknowledges his or her roots after being catapulted into a stratosphere where the noise of success would make lesser men forget. Blackwell is disarming, dressed modestly in jeans and T-shirts. Yet while he may appear down-to-earth—people on the street stop and address him affectionately as 'CB'—his vision is ambitious. This becomes clear when the next morning I ride out over his farm, Pantrepant, and learn of his plans for this old plantation where no chemical fertilisers or pesticides have been used for the two decades it has been in Blackwell's possession. He has added not a single flashy eyesore, not a note of bling. This is a man who prefers bathing in a natural swimming pool fashioned from an 18th-century molasses vault with lichen-covered sides, who prefers swimming in rivers even more. He believes there are others like him—wealthy, successful people who don't seek the accoutrements of conventional luxury but peace, beauty and quiet. He believes these same people have a desire to live more naturally, that they might just want to give something back. This is why he is developing plans to turn Pantrepant into a community of 80 private houses (the ground rent contributing to Pantrepant's running costs) and an 800-acre organic farm managed by Jamaicans—underprivileged city kids—who will train at Pantrepant in new agricultural techniques. "I believe in the future—the near-future," says Blackwell, who has already formed an alliance between Panetrepant and EARTH University, a progressive agricultural university based in Costa Rica that pioneers techniques in tropical humid farming: "I believe it's now possible to live off the grid and do anything. It used to be that if you did something like this, you checked out of the world. Not any more."

But Pantrepant is not why I'm on Jamaica. I'm here to visit GoldenEye, Ian Fleming's former home that Blackwell has recently transformed into the best resort in the Caribbean. Not 'best' because of gold taps and butler services, but best because I've never found a place like it in a part of the world that's so often accused of being bereft of soul—of authenticity. Yet GoldenEye, like its owner, oozes quiet confidence, integrity and a very specific Jamaican spirit.

"If you're independent you have to be counter," Blackwell says: "A small army can never beat a big army but a guerrilla force can." The man made it work with music, and he's bent on making it work with this next phase in his life: to better present Jamaica to the world, not through giant branding initiatives but with his group of characterful hotels—Strawberry Hill, The Caves, and now GoldenEye—while showing how Jamaica has more to offer than beaches, drugs and the Kingston ghetto. To make this impact, however, doesn't mean calling upon the usual bells and whistles; nor, contends Blackwell, is it about cutting off travellers from the realities and quirks of the place they're visiting. What people really want is to feel comfortably immersed.

I stay at GoldenEye for a night. With a location such as this on the water's edge, I want to keep the shutters open and hear the surf. I want to listen to crickets in the tropical vegetation, and the plop of leaves falling into the emerald pools of the lagoon. I want to hear the sound of reggae coming from the nearby town of Oracabessa. I suspect that Blackwell wants me to hear it too. It's one of the reasons he offers every guest a $25 per person per day credit to their bill if they turn off their air-conditioning. With it on, "You don't feel the air, hear the birds," he explains.

Because hearing, *feeling*, Jamaica is what Blackwell believes will persuade people to fall in love with this island he calls home. He doesn't want GoldenEye's guests to feel like prisoners of the resort's restaurants; he'd rather encourage them to go out and eat in the town, a one-time port for the banana trade on the island's north coast where from 1949 Fleming came for three months of

> I believe it's now possible to live off the grid and do anything. It used to be that if you did something like this, you checked out of the world. Not any more"

PADDLING OUT FROM GOLDENEYE'S SHORES

The Experientialist
Available on the App Store

> If you're independent you have to be counter," Blackwell says: "A small army can never beat a big army but a guerrilla force can"

FIELD SPA AT GOLDENEYE BESIDE THE LAGOON

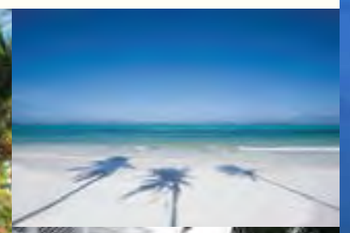
every year to write his spy novels. Nor does Blackwell import Asian staff, as is the trend in other parts of the Caribbean. At GoldenEye, more than 90 per cent of those working at the resort are Jamaican—"it's about hiring local people with personality," says Blackwell—with nearly all from Oracabessa. Nor will you find any Kobe beef on the menus. The cuisine reflects the flavours of Jamaica's home kitchens—saltfish and ackee, curried goat—with local farmers and fishermen providing the produce as well as Pantrepant, the organic produce sent directly to the kitchen at GoldenEye, where guests, literally, get to taste the fruits and vegetables from Blackwell's farm. As to the rooms and suites, they include the original three-bedroom Fleming Villa (sketched by the author on his desk blotter), with two new one-bedroom guest cottages, as well as eight one- and two-bedroom candy-coloured cottages in wooden clapperboard with cedar-shingle roofs facing the lagoon. This is where Blackwell's own cottage sits: an octagonal hut, each side 7ft long, with a small adjoining bathroom, simple outdoor shower, and stone steps down to the water.

All this development has been revealed over the last 18 months, yet Blackwell, I learn, has owned the land since 1976 as well as another two miles of coastline adjoining GoldenEye's site. He says the resort is just the start: in the years to come, he sees a town, a community reinvigorated and a marina to one side of the marine sanctuary he has already established to resuscitate the reef. When I ask why he hasn't done it all immediately, he points out that too much too soon in tourism is a dangerous thing. Besides, "the record industry is a good way to learn patience," he says: "You have to wait forever for someone to tune their guitar."

That's the thing about Blackwell: the world might be moving at speed, but he won't do anything in a hurry. He rejects the rapacity of the industry, of the quick-buck mass tourism that afflicts other parts of the island. If he has a legacy in mind, it's to persuade the rich to give more thought to the way they consume while encouraging Jamaica to rise up above its negative reputation. "When nobody cares about something, you can feel it," says Blackwell. So even if the road up to his home is a pot-holed mess, don't be fooled: Blackwell cares from the bottom of his heart—about his track, his farm, about the island he calls home and how its authenticity is perceived and experienced by the rest of the world.

WORDS - SOPHY ROBERTS

Baraza
RESORT & SPA
ZANZIBAR



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Act One.

Challenger brand insights from Adam Morgan

A couple of years ago I went to see Tom Ford speak about his first film, A Single Man. The critic of The Times was on stage with him, asking him about the making of the film, and his vision for it, and at the end they turned it over to the audience for questions. So I stuck my hand up.

I'd read that he described his sense of his catwalk shows as 'filmic', and asked him what he meant by this – what he has taken from the world of film into the world of fashion. Until then he had been leaning back in his seat- witty, engaging, poised. But now his body language changed, and he leant forward. His voice became rather more urgent, more compelled, less reflective, as if rising to the challenge of that catwalk – and as if the challenge of that temporary theatre, that small catwalk performed to a tiny audience for just one afternoon, was a steeper and more demanding challenge than that of making a film that will be viewable by anyone in the world, and will last forever.

He said:
'In a fashion show you have 13 minutes to convince a room of 200 people of your vision.'
He repeated the time:
'13 minutes.'
He continued 'And this is a very cynical, seen-it-all audience in this room. So you have to have an idea. And then you have to tell a story.
So you need a big start. Boom! Act One. Out it comes. And as you start to tell your story you have to really focus the audience. I turn the lights off and have a spotlight on the stage, otherwise they are all waving to their friends and checking their phones.
You start to tell your story and you move on. Boom! Act Two. On you take them.
I use music very deliberately to try to control the audience's emotions. To help control the rhythm in the room. And after a while you can hear the breathing of the room (he inhaled and exhaled at this point). 'You can start to feel them reacting together to your story. It is palpable. Till at the end as you finish they all exhale (and he exhales a big breath at this point) at the same time.'

He was a hugely stimulating speaker. And I was very struck by a number of things he emphasized in conveying his sense of how to communicate a vision. Struck by how useful they could be for us as owners and drivers of Challenger Brands when it comes to communicating our stories, convincing our own audiences of our vision. When it comes to translating our Saying into Doing. It's a little prosaic to spell it out, point by point, but indulge me while I do that anyway, because I think each is worth focusing on.

13 Minutes

He didn't say 'you don't have long', or 'you have around a quarter of an hour'. He said '13 minutes'. Twice. He knew exactly how long he had to make the impact he needed. And it was the tension between the time he had, the importance of success, and the lurking cynicism of the audience that gave an urgency and drama to how he decided to do everything that followed.

So…Let's understand exactly how long we have to convince our audience of our vision, how long we have to make the impact we need. And let's use this fixed time frame to give urgency and drama to everything that follows. Note here that we are not necessarily talking about external audiences. It could be our CEO, our sales team, our R&D scientists. Anyone we need to enlist and excite.

Act One

He is telling a story without words. So he sees each appearance on the catwalk is an Act. Each Act tells a part of the overall story. And these Acts are thus not simply connected, they are sequenced.
So…What are the five key Acts that will together convey our vision? What is the right sequence for them? How does this sequence of Acts build our story?

Boom!

These actions are intended to create a sense of drama, and arresting Ford's audience at the beginning of each act is critical. So his ambition for each one is to start with 'Boom!' A very striking word. If you wanted to have the effect of 'Boom!', you're not talking about getting heads nodding, or quiet agreement. You are talking about really getting them to sit up and take notice.

So…What would it mean to define our ambition for each act as Boom! What kind of response would we be looking for, not just at the end, but at the beginning of each Act? How can we more theatrically engage with our audience right from the start of each element of our storytelling?

The Spotlight

Even in a Tom Ford fashion show, if the audience can get distracted they will. He can't allow that. Even drama is no guarantee of attention. Tom Ford forces his audience to focus their attention. What is our equivalent to his spotlight, and where are we going to focus it?

Music

In reality, the notion of a viewer of our spectacle is wrong. Ford knows he will not succeed by engaging his group's eyes alone – he has to engage their emotions. He is going to think about how he can use every sensory trigger at his disposal to do that. What are the sensory triggers at our disposal? How can we use them to engage every sense to bring our audience along with us?

Exhale

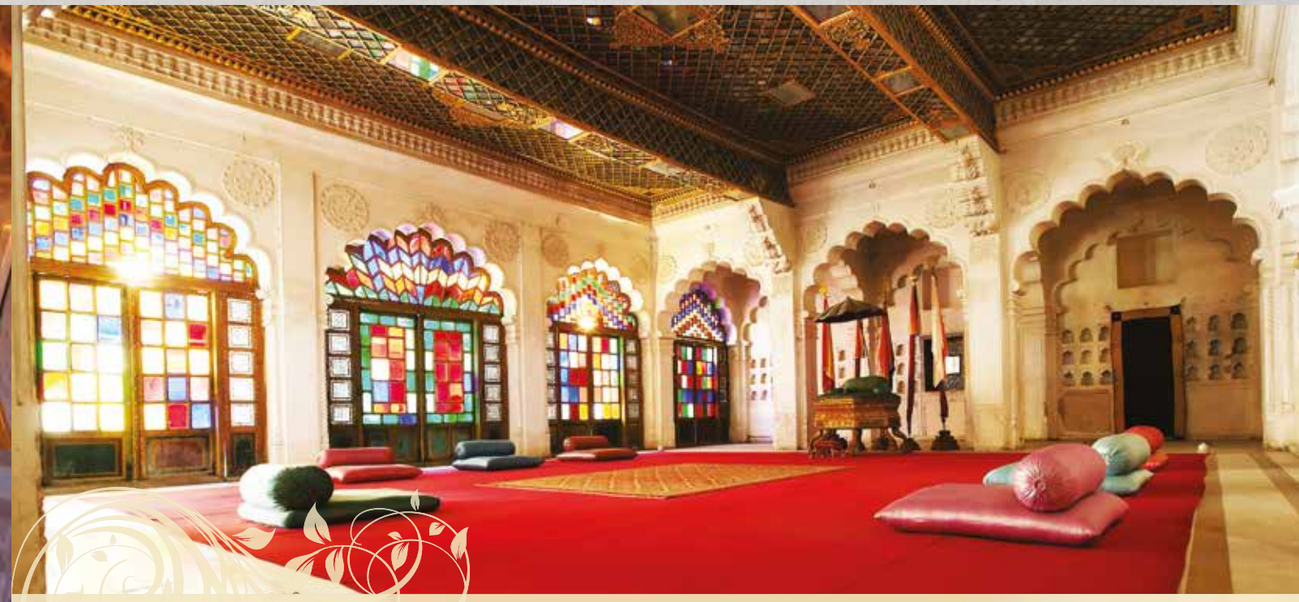
Ford has a whole new metric for emotional engagement. One that is – in his words – 'palpable': whether the audience breathe in and out at the same time. If they exhale together at the end, he has succeeded. If they don't, it hasn't worked as he intended it to.

Hugely demanding, but very simple, very clear, very measurable. So what is our metric for emotional engagement? That is hugely demanding, but very simple and clear and measurable? That is palpable?

And he has also denied himself something critical, that most of us rely on more than we should: he has denied himself words. I am not suggesting that we do this ourselves, but I am intrigued by Pinter's observations that 'words are sometimes just a strategy to cover nakedness' – and that forcing yourself to be less dependent on words requires you to have more substance, as well as more theatre (Rob Poynton talks about this in his short film this month). That if as Challenger Brands, and as owners of Challenger Brands, we thought more in terms of 'Boom! Act One!' then actually we would not find ourselves all too often dressing up the insubstantial, but the very opposite – pushing ourselves to greater substance.

Of course, there are also limits to this analogy for many of us. Ford has at one level a captive audience, for instance – they cannot leave the room. And that is certainly not true of our external audiences for us.
But then most of us are not presenting to as tough an audience as Nuclear Wintour, either.

Adam Morgan, Founder of eatbigfish



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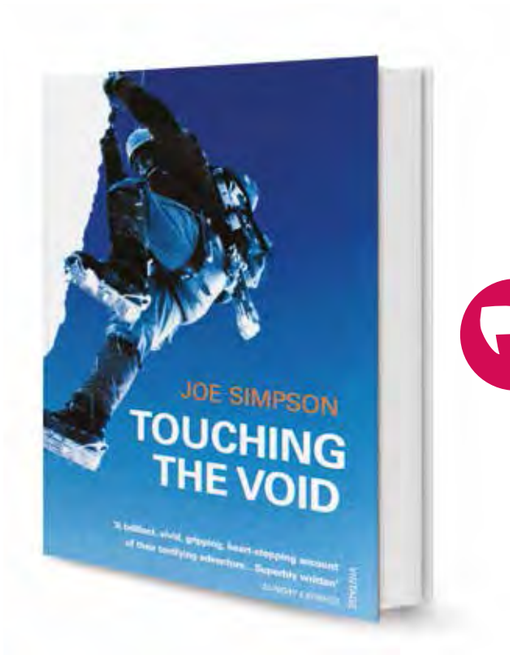
Read on for a taster of the most spine-tingling, gripping novels by ordinary and not so ordinary people embarking on extraordinary journeys. Ranging from the incredible real life tale of two daring mountain climbers who found themselves facing an icy end – now a motion picture - to a River Amazon adventurer who walked with the flow from source to its journeys end, these inspiring tales will leave you ready to get out there and test your mettle. Or just very glad not to be dangling off an ice-ledge supported by a single crampon (don't worry; we didn't give away the ending).

Enjoy...



‘Touching the Void’

by Joe Simpson.

Taken from Chapter Seven of ‘Touching the Void’ by Joe Simpson.

So! It ends here. Pity! I hope somebody finds us, and knows we climbed the West Face. I don’t want to disappear without trace. They’d never know we did it. The wind swung me in a gentle circle. I looked at the crevasse beneath me, waiting for me. It was big. Twenty feet wide at least. I guessed that I was hanging fifty feet above it. It stretched along the base of the ice cliff. Below me it was covered with a roof of snow, but to the right it opened out and a dark space yawned there. Bottomless, I thought idly. No. They’re never bottomless. I wonder how deep I will go? To the bottom… to the water at the bottom? God! I hope not!

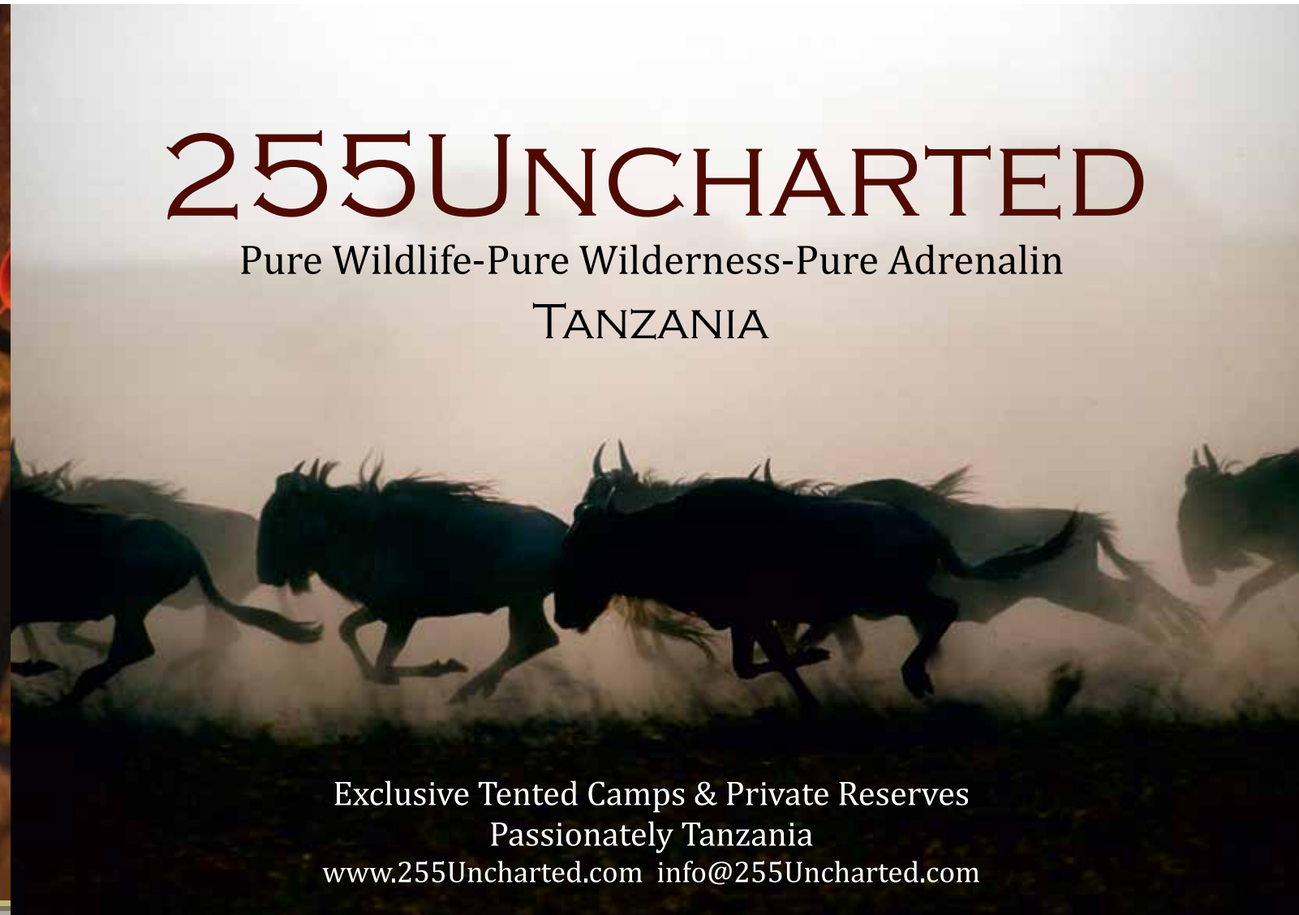
Another jerk. Above me the rope sawed through the cliff edge, dislodging chunks of crusty ice. I stared at it stretching into the darkness above. Cold had long since won its battle. There was no feeling in my arms and legs. Everything slowed and softened. Thoughts became idle questions, never answered. I accepted that I was to die. There was no alternative. It caused me no dreadful fear. I was numb with cold and felt no pain; so senselessly cold that I craved sleep and cared nothing for the consequences. It would be a dreamless sleep. Reality had become a nightmare, and sleep beckoned insistently; a black hole calling me, pain-free, lost in time, like death.

My torch beam died. The cold had killed the batteries. I saw stars in a dark gap above me. Stars, or lights in my head. The storm was over. The stars were good to see. I was glad to see them again. Old friends come back. They seemed far away; further than I’d ever seen them before. And bright: you’d think them gemstones hanging there, floating in the air above. Some moved, little winking moves, on and off, on and off, floating the brightest sparks of light down to me.

Then, what I had waited for pounced on me. The stars went out, and I fell. Like something come alive, the rope lashed violently against my face and I fell silently, endlessly into nothingness, as if dreaming of falling. I fell fast, faster than thought, and my stomach protested at the swooping speed of it. I swept down, and from far above I saw myself falling and felt nothing. No thoughts, and all fears gone away. So this is it!

A whoomphing impact on my back broke the dream, and the snow engulfed me. I felt cold wetness on my cheeks. I wasn’t stopping, and for an instant blinding moment I was frightened. Now, the crevasse! Ahhh… NO!! The acceleration took me again, mercifully fast, too fast for the scream which died above me…

Available through Joe’s website www.noordinaryjoe.co.uk



‘Walking the Amazon’

By Ed Stafford

In April 2008, ex-soldier and explorer Ed Stafford began his attempt to become the first man ever to walk the entire length of the River Amazon from its source in southern Peru to its mouth on the Brazilian coast.

He believed it would take one year and involve walking 4,000 miles. In the end, two and a half years and 6,000 miles later, Ed would make it to journey’s end on the Atlantic. Along the way he had climbed an 18,000 ft mountain; filmed never-before-seen tribal ceremonies; eaten cactus, tortoises and tapirs; been mistaken for a white man buying human organs and met a remarkable local guide named Cho, who accompanied Ed on his mammoth trek.

This is a vivid portrait of a man driven to the edge of his own sanity to join the ranks of the greatest explorers of all time. We highly recommend it

After receiving a very direct warning over the HF radio that we would be killed if we decided to continue our journey, we reach the downriver end of the shingle island in the middle of the Amazon. I drop my inflated pack raft into the shallow brown waters and roll my heavy backpack off my stiff, grimy back and into the rubber boat.
‘Mira, Ed, atrás. Look, Ed, behind you,’ says Cho calmly. As I turn I see five dugout canoes coming towards us fast, full of indigenous Indians. Many of the Indians are standing up in the narrow boats; bows drawn, arrows trained on us. Those who are seated are thrusting hard with big wooden paddles.
My T-shirt clings to my body and sweat pours down my temples. My body is still but my heart is quickening, adrenaline pours into my brain allowing me to process the imminent danger rapidly. My perception of time slows down. The carved boats cut through the choppy river fluently. The dangerous scene in the middle distance is framed by a green wall of overhanging jungle beyond. The brown faces of the Asheninka men and women are warlike and fierce, highlighted by lines of bright red face paint. I notice the women are all clutching machetes.

Taken from ‘Walking the Amazon’ By Ed Stafford.

‘In Shackleton’s Footsteps’

By Henry Worsley

On the 29th of October 1908, a party of four men, led by Ernest Shackleton, set out to be the first to reach the South Pole. Three months later, their mission was in ruins and they faced certain death if they carried on. Just 97 miles from the South Pole, Shackleton turned back.

One hundred years on, in October 2008, a team that included descendants of that original party, led by Henry Worsley, set out from Shackleton’s hut to celebrate the centenary of his expedition by retracing the exact 870 mile route and going on to finish the last 97 miles. This captivating book explores the history of the original expedition and reasons behind its failure, while capturing the meticulous planning, fundraising and training for the new expedition. There is also the team’s first days on the ice, Christmas on the polar plateau, the brutal reality of crossing the Beardmore Glacier and the final miles to the South Pole. In Shackleton’s Footsteps is a unique story of adventure, pioneering spirit and man’s triumph over nature.

I turned inland from the water’s edge and walked the slight slope over the tussock grass towards the white picket fence. I opened the gate and headed to the back of the enclosure, where I stopped. Turning around I sat down on the rucksack and stared out across the bay, the water rippling in the weakening light. The feeling of the excitement on doing something that had seemed beyond all possibility, yet was now actually about to happen, wrapped itself around me.
I unpacked my sleeping bag, wriggled inside it and, settling down into the gathering warmth, turned to face the upright block of granite at arm’s length from my face. The metal lettering hammered into the rough face of the stone was just visible. Reaching out to touch it I considered for a moment just how significant a moment in my life this was; all my life I’d hoped one day to be here. I was about to spend the night in a whaler’s cemetery in Grytviken on the island of South Georgia beside the grave of my hero since childhood – Sir Ernest Shackleton.

Taken from ‘In Shackleton’s Footsteps’ By Ed Stafford.

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JAPAN

Travel after Tragedy: Duff Trimble is the founder and managing director of Wabi-Sabi Japan, a destination expert for high-end travellers to the country. Following on from the Fukushima disaster in Japan, he shares his insights into a tour operator's role when tragedy strikes. And what that can mean to a traveller's world view

ON March 11, 2011 a devastating earthquake and subsequent tsunami ravaged the northeast coast of the Japanese island of Honshu. As surreal videos of the tsunami's destructive force reached the airwaves, a much greater threat was revealed at the Fukushima Daichi nuclear plant. Explosions of hydrogen and uncertainty about the state of the reactors provided sensational fodder for the world media, which left the residents of Japan fearing for their safety.

While the news was tragic at every level, the timing could not have occurred at a worse time for the Japanese inbound tourism industry. The busiest and most lucrative season for all service providers—guides, hotels, ryokans, restaurants, travel companies—is the spring period from the middle of March to the end of April.

Immediately following the news, almost all inbound tours and travel scheduled for this period were cancelled or postponed. Despite statistics provided by JNTO (Japanese National Tourist Organization) showing a 50 to 60 per cent drop in tourist numbers, the reality on the ground was far more severe. In my discussions with hoteliers and ryokan owners the general figure put overseas business at around five per cent of the 2010 levels. Indeed, only the most intrepid travellers and businesspeople continued with their plans to visit the country.

Initially I focused on communicating with everyone in Japan to make sure they were safe. We corresponded with clients, managing the postponements and cancellations of their trips. Then in May I travelled through Japan for three weeks, ostensibly to visit my staff, guides, contacts in the travel industry and personal friends. The mood was very sombre. Despite the stoic outward demeanour that garnered the world's admiration, it was clear people were depressed and anxious over the uncertainty of Fukushima Daichi and the continued suffering of survivors. For those in the travel business, the outlook was, of course, exceedingly bleak. Being essentially contract workers, most guides earn a substantial portion of their yearly earnings in the months of March, April and May. Many of them banded together to produce videos uploaded onto YouTube extolling the beauty of the cherry blossom season and the relative safety of areas like Tokyo, Kyoto and western Japan that were outside the stricken zone. However, the bright smiles of the videos could not hide the fact they knew most of this lucrative season was a lost cause.

After a month passed, emails started to appear from various suppliers in Japan announcing that travel to most of the country or to specific locations was fine, so please come. At the time, I respectfully disagreed with this assessment; I was not comfortable endorsing travel to the country. I felt there remained great uncertainty about Fukushima and the potential for aftershocks. I considered the correct action was to educate any clients about the realities on the ground. I also believed the Japanese people were not ready to fully welcome visitors with their usual level of omotenashi (hospitality) due to those very present feelings of anxiety and depression.

In the autumn, I travelled through the country again to try and understand what was happening on the ground and how I should respond with the passing of time. In truth, it took six months for the mood to change, to be replaced by a positive determination among the Japanese to try and move forward. In the travel industry, however, the situation was less flexible.

Whether it is Egypt after riots, Lamu after kidnappings, or Japan after an earthquake, the travel industry always proves itself capricious. There are an infinite number of choices where one can spend one's travel dollars. Since Fukushima, it has therefore been an easy decision to avoid Japan. Yet after a tragedy such as that of March 11, 2011, a morale boost matters more than ever when family-owned ryokans, independent guides, drivers of private sedans and taxis and many others are facing one of the most difficult financial struggles in living memory.

To travel responsibly is to travel safely, but it is also about an essential cross-cultural experience and the tremendous psychological effect that dynamic can have. One year on and business has picked up dramatically; Japan is still beautiful and mysterious and far more besides. But now my clients talk not only of ancient temples and delicious cuisine but also the deep sense of gratitude and happiness among the Japanese they meet.

I have always thought travel serves as a great vehicle to connect to citizens of other lands. In Japan today it also now serves to help the healing.

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